Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Kings

1 Kings 1:1–3

David was seventy years old (2 Samuel 5:4–5). He was weak, likely due to years of war and stress. He needed a young person to provide warmth. This was a medical remedy also mentioned in Josephus's Antiquities and by the Greek doctor Galen. David's weakening strength encouraged Adonijah to try to make himself king.

1 Kings 1:1–2.12

The book of 1 Kings begins with the Lord's promise to David (see 2 Samuel 7:11–16). Solomon was the rightful and God-chosen heir to what God gave his father David. The problems during Solomon's rise to power suggested there would be more troubles later in his reign and between Israel and Judah in the future(1 Kings 1:1–2:46; 11:12–43).

1 Kings 1:5–6

Adonijah was David's fourth son. His older brothers, Amnon, Daniel, and Absalom, had died. So, Adonijah thought he would become king. However, according to ancient Near Eastern tradition, Solomon, the son of David's favorite wife Bathsheba, was to become king. David had already told Solomon about this (1 Kings 1:13, 17; 1 Chronicles 22:6–10). Adonijah's ambition, likely encouraged by his father's lenient discipline, showed when he declared, "I will be king!"

1 Kings 1:7

Joab, the leader of David's army, and Abiathar, the high priest, supported Adonijah with strong military and religious support in his pursuit to become king.

1 Kings 1:8

Solomon had powerful friends who supported his claim to be king. Zadok came from the priestly line of Eleazar. Benaiah led David's bodyguard and his thirty mighty men (2 Samuel 23:20–23). Shimei was one of Solomon's district governors (1 Kings 4:18). Nathan was a trusted prophet of David. Rei is not known beyond this verse.

1 Kings 1:9

En-rogel, now known as Bir Ayyub or "Job's well," is located south of Jerusalem where the Kidron and Hinnom valleys meet. In the past, it was the hiding place for David's two informants, Jonathan and Ahimaaz, during Absalom's rebellion (see 2 Samuel 17:17).

1 Kings 1:11–14

- Bathsheba was Solomon's mother and David's favorite wife. Their affair caused the death of Bathsheba's husband, Uriah the Hittite (see 2 Samuel 11:1–27).
- Nathan, the prophet who shared God's promise with David (2 Samuel 7:1–17) and announced God's love for Solomon at his birth (2 Samuel 12:24–25), confirmed God's choice of Solomon to become king after David (see 1 Chronicles 28:4–7). Although Nathan strongly criticized David for his affair with Bathsheba and the murder of Uriah (2 Samuel 12:1–15), the king respected him.
- Adonijah likely noticed Nathan's close ties with Bathsheba and Solomon. If Adonijah's plan to make himself king succeeded, all three could expect to be killed (see 1 Kings 15:29; 16:11).

1 Kings 1:28–30

David comforted Bathsheba by promising again, in God's name, that Solomon would be the next king (see 1 Kings 1:17).

1 Kings 1:31–32

David confirmed his promise by calling for a public show of support. The priest Zadok, the prophet Nathan, and the military leader Benaiah supported him as representatives of their groups.

1 Kings 1:33

- Riding the king's mule showed high status. An ancient text from Mari advised King Zimri-Lim to follow royal protocol by riding in a donkey cart. David's sons rode mules (2 Samuel 13:29; 18:9). Similarly, Zechariah predicts that Israel's king will come "riding on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey" (Zechariah 9:9), a prophecy fulfilled by Jesus (Matthew 21:4–7; John 12:14–15). When Solomon rode David's royal mule, it showed that David approved of Solomon becoming king.
- The Gihon Spring was the main water source for Jerusalem. It was just outside the city's eastern slopes. People often gathered there, so Solomon's anointing would be widely known. But those who supported Adonijah at En-rogel could not see it.

1 Kings 1:34

- Solomon's anointing followed the usual process and was performed by a prophet (see 1 Samuel 16:1–13).
- Priests were important in royal events, and people appreciated Zadok's blessing. David later publicly confirmed Solomon as king (1 Chronicles 29:22).

1 Kings 1:35

- sit on my throne: Because David was old and weak, Solomon led publicly for about two years before David died. Sharing the throne ensured a smooth royal succession and became common during Israel's divided monarchy. It was also used in Egypt.
- The Hebrew word for ruler, used for different leadership roles, can have religious importance. The king was seen as both a spiritual and administrative leader of God's people (see Deuteronomy 31:10–11; 1 Chronicles 28:4–6; Psalm 89:3–4; Isaiah 55:3–4).

1 Kings 1:38

The king's bodyguards were foreign soldiers from Crete. They served David during his entire reign (2 Samuel 8:18; 15:18; 20:7).

1 Kings 1:39

The priest anointed Solomon with olive oil. This common Near Eastern practice gave the ceremony a divine blessing.

1 Kings 1:40–41

The people at Adonijah's banquet in En-rogel could not see the celebration, but it was so loud and joyful that they could hear it.

1 Kings 1:42–49

Solomon was proclaimed king and the people welcomed him with joy. Adonijah and his followers panicked. They ran away, and their attempt to make Adonijah king failed.

1 Kings 1:50–53

Fearing for his life, Adonijah sought safety at the horns (projections at the corners) of the altar (Exodus 27:2), hoping for mercy based on biblical tradition (see Exodus 21:12–14). However, this protection was only for accidental killings, so only the king could forgive Adonijah's treason. Solomon showed him kindness if he stayed loyal. Despite appearances, Adonijah still tried to make himself king and was later killed for causing trouble (1 Kings 2:13–25).

1 Kings 2:1–12

David gave Solomon his final advice in two parts:

- personal guidance for spiritual living (1 Kings 2:2–4) and
- directions about people David had interacted with (1 Kings 2:5–9).

1 Kings 2:2

So be strong and prove yourself a man: God and Moses gave this same advice to Joshua during the conquest (Deuteronomy 31:6–7; Joshua 1:6–7, 9). Joshua and Hezekiah encouraged the Israelite forces when facing enemies (Joshua 1:16–18; 10:24–28; 2 Chronicles 32:7). David understood the importance of courage from God (Psalms 27:13–14; 31:23–24).

When Paul urged Christians to be brave and strong (1 Corinthians 16:13), he used the same words found in the Greek Old Testament for the advice given by Moses, Joshua, Hezekiah, and the Lord. A similar situation occurred during Bishop Polycarp's martyrdom. As he was led to execution, Polycarp heard a voice from heaven saying, "Be strong, Polycarp, be a man!" (Martyrdom of Polycarp 9:1).

1 Kings 2:2–4

- David advised Solomon to follow the spiritual and ethical rules from Deuteronomy and the covenant through Moses (see Leviticus 18:4–5; Deuteronomy 5:33; 6:4–5; 8:6; 10:12). He also mentioned the promises of the covenant with David (2 Samuel 7:12–16, 25). If Solomon followed God's rules, his heir would receive God's blessings and pass them to future generations (Psalm 89:3–4, 20, 24, 27–37).
- The most important heir of David was the Messiah. The Messiah would:
- show true righteousness (Isaiah 11:1–5),
- gain all the benefits of the covenant (Jeremiah 33:14–16), and
- create a new covenant with Israel and Judah (Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 34:24–31; 37:24–28).

The New Testament identifies Jesus as that son of David who has come (Matthew 1:1; Romans 1:1–4). He will return to fulfill Old Testament prophecies and bless everyone (Luke 1:67–79; Galatians 3:26–29; Revelation 3:21).

1 Kings 2:5–6

Joab had supported David's rise to kingship but became too ambitious. He murdered former military rivals Abner (2 Samuel 3:22–30) and Amasa (2 Samuel 20:10), as well as David's son Absalom (2 Samuel 18:1–18). Involved in David's murder of Uriah the Hittite (2 Samuel 11:14–27), Joab became very powerful (2 Samuel 20:23), and his support for Adonijah was a serious threat to Solomon.

1 Kings 2:7

at your table: Like he did for Mephibosheth (2 Samuel 9:6–13), David took care of Barzillai and his family. This privilege ensured their continued loyalty.

1 Kings 2:7–9

Barzillai strongly supported David during his conflict with Absalom, while Shimei openly opposed David (2 Samuel 16:5–13; 19:6–23).

1 Kings 2:8

Mahanaim was where David found safety during Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 17:24). The Egyptian pharaoh, Shishak, attacked it when Rehoboam was king (see 1 Kings 14:25).

1 Kings 2:10–12

David died peacefully after ruling for forty years, confident that Solomon, his chosen heir, would lead the kingdom. People have suggested different locations for David's tomb, but none are confirmed (see Acts 2:29). Royal tombs were in use at least until the time of Hezekiah (2 Kings 20:21).

1 Kings 2:13–15

Adonijah showed he was not peaceful when he claimed, "You know that the kingship was mine."

1 Kings 2:16–18

Let him give me Abishag the Shunammite as my wife: Having the king's concubine showed royal authority. When David became king, he received Saul's wives (2 Samuel 12:7–8). The rebellious Absalom took David's concubines (2 Samuel 16:20–22).

1 Kings 2:19–21

Solomon realized Adonijah's true intentions with his small request. Adonijah wanted to marry Abishag to strengthen his claim to the throne, regardless of her status in David's harem.

1 Kings 2:22–25

Adonijah broke his agreement to submit to Solomon (1 Kings 1:52–53). So the king told Benaiah to execute him (see 1 Kings 1:8, 26, 38).

1 Kings 2:26–27

Abiathar had supported Adonijah in his attempt to make himself king (1 Kings 1:7, 25). But he was removed from his position instead of being killed because he had:

- carried the ark (2 Samuel 15:24, 29, 35),
- supported David, and
- shared in David's hardships.

Abiathar's removal from the priesthood fulfilled God's word about Eli's family line through Ithamar (1 Samuel 2:30–35). Zadok's appointment (1 Kings 4:2) restored the high priesthood to Eleazar's line, as it was before Eli (Numbers 20:22–28; 25:11–13; 2 Samuel 8:17; 1 Chronicles 6:1–8, 50–53; Ezra 7:2–5) and continued during Israel's divided kingdom (2 Chronicles 31:10; Ezekiel 43:19).

1 Kings 2:26–35

Solomon believed that Adonijah's main supporters, Abiathar and Joab, were still part of Adonijah's plans, so he took action against them too.

1 Kings 2:28–29

Joab followed Adonijah's example (1 Kings 1:50). Joab hoped for mercy by holding onto the altar's horns, as allowed by the law of Moses (Exodus 21:12–14; Numbers 35:22–25; Deuteronomy 19:4–5). However, because Joab was a murderer, he could not receive mercy (see 2 Samuel 3:27; 18:14; 20:10).

1 Kings 2:36–38

Shimei was confined so that he could not go to his relatives in Benjamin and cause problems for the king.

1 Kings 2:39–46

Shimei went to Gath to find his runaway slaves. This broke the agreement he made. He did no cross the Kidron Valley, but both parties knew the penalty applied if he went anywhere else. Shimei broke his promise to the Lord (1 Kings 2:43) and had a history of hostility toward David (2 Samuel 16:5–13; 19:16–23). Because of this, Solomon told Benaiah to execute him.

1 Kings 3:1

- In the ancient Near East, it was common for rulers to form alliances through marriage. Solomon married an Egyptian princess to strengthen ties with Egypt. The Egyptian king gave Solomon the city of Gezer as a wedding gift (1 Kings 9:16), showing respect for Solomon. The Egyptian king was likely Siamun from the weakened 21st dynasty. The alliance was mutually beneficial: Pharaoh gained access to trade routes through Israel, while Solomon increased security on his southern border. Solomon had also married Naamah from Ammon (see 1 Kings 11:42–43 with 14:21).

- City of David: This part of Jerusalem was the old Jebusite city on the southern part of the eastern ridge. When Solomon expanded his building projects north, he constructed a special palace for Pharaoh's daughter (1 Kings 7:8; 9:24; 2 Chronicles 8:11).

1 Kings 3:2–3

The ark of the covenant was in David's tent in Jerusalem before the temple was built. During this time, people made sacrifices at local worship sites (see study note on 1 Kings 8:1). This practice reduced unified worship at a central place (1 Kings 12:1–24). It also increased the risk of adopting Canaanite religious practices. Worshiping at these local sites was forbidden for Israel (Deuteronomy 12:1–14).

1 Kings 3:4

The city of Gibeon was six miles northwest of Jerusalem. Its altar was known as the great high place. It was a major worship site for large sacrifices. Gibeon also hosted the tabernacle (a sacred tent used for worship) (1 Chronicles 16:39–40; 21:29; 2 Chronicles 1:2–6).

1 Kings 3:4–15

The story of God giving wisdom to Solomon is told as a chiasm (a mirrored structure where A and B reflect B' and A'). It highlights Solomon's interaction with the Lord:

- A: While Solomon was sacrificing at Gibeon, the Lord appeared to him in a dream (1 Kings 3:4–5).
- B: Solomon asked for wisdom to govern his people fairly and effectively (1 Kings 3:6–9).
- B': The Lord agreed to his request and gave him extra blessings (1 Kings 3:10–14).
- A': Solomon woke up from the dream and made more sacrifices to the Lord (1 Kings 3:15).

1 Kings 3:6

The Hebrew word khesed is often translated "faithful love." It describes God's gracious and kind treatment of people (Psalm 118:1–2). God shows this faithful love especially to Israel, the nation with whom he made a covenant (Deuteronomy 7:9, 12).

1 Kings 3:7–9

The Hebrew term for little child often referred to someone inexperienced in their job, like an "assistant" (1 Kings 19:21). Solomon humbly admitted his lack of experience and his need for wisdom. He understood that to govern the people well and make good decisions, he needed God's help.

1 Kings 3:10–12

God was pleased with Solomon's selfless request and gave him a wise and understanding heart. These unique qualities are shown in the next section (1 Kings 3:16–28) and as Solomon organizes his administration (1 Kings 4), business dealings, construction projects, international relations, and worship practices (1 Kings 5–10).

1 Kings 3:15

Solomon's sacrifice after the dream completes the story.

1 Kings 3:16

prostitutes: The law condemned prostitution (Leviticus 19:29; Deuteronomy 23:18), but it still existed in ancient Israel. These women were among the most looked down upon in Israelite society. However, Solomon showed kindness and fairness to them by treating them as mothers, not just as prostitutes.

1 Kings 3:16–28

Solomon's decision about the true mother of the living baby shows his wisdom in legal matters. First Kings 4–10 show his wisdom in all parts of his rule.

1 Kings 3:28

Kings often said they had special wisdom and could make fair decisions. God promised that Solomon's wisdom was greater than other wise men (1 Kings 4:29–34; 10:6–9, 23–24).

1 Kings 4:2

Zadok was very old, so his grandson Azariah became the high priest (see 1 Chronicles 6:8–9).

1 Kings 4:3

- The court secretaries were state officials and Solomon's private secretaries. Shisha, the father of Elihoreph and Ahijah, had served David in this role (2 Samuel 8:17; 20:25; 1 Chronicles 18:16).
- The royal historian acted as the chief of protocol for palace events and ceremonies. In ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia, these officials often represented the king in important talks (see 2 Kings 18:18; 2 Chronicles 34:8).

1 Kings 4:4

Benaiah ... Zadok and Abiathar: All three held important positions in David's administration. Even though Abiathar was removed as high priest (1 Kings 2:26–27), he continued to serve as a priest.

1 Kings 4:5

Two of Nathan's sons were also part of Solomon's inner circle. Azariah managed the twelve district governors, while Zabud was a trusted adviser, a role Hushai held under David (2 Samuel 15:37).

1 Kings 4:6

- Ahishar managed the palace property, a role that gained power under Jotham, son of Uzziah (2 Kings 15:5). Later, Eliakim held this position. He was one of Hezekiah's representatives and met with King Sennacherib of Assyria's envoys during talks about the siege of Jerusalem (2 Kings 18:18).
- Adoniram led the corvée (the system of forced labor). Samuel had warned about this disliked practice (1 Samuel 8:12–17), and Israel's leaders later complained about it to Solomon's son, Rehoboam (1 Kings 12:4).

1 Kings 4:7–19

The twelve district governors likely managed smaller tasks, like collecting taxes and supplying food for the king's household. Solomon's twelve districts did not match the old tribal areas exactly.

1 Kings 4:20–21

God promised Abraham land (Genesis 15:18–21; 17:8; 22:17). This promise came true with Solomon's blessing. The lands that David and Solomon (2 Chronicles 8:3) conquered stayed loyal to Solomon. They sent him tribute money and served him throughout his long reign.

1 Kings 4:22–23

Solomon's court was huge and impressive, shown by the large amount of food it needed each day.

1 Kings 4:24–25

Each family had its own home and garden. Solomon's people lived in ideal conditions, hinting at the future messianic era (Micah 4:4), enjoying prosperity and peace.

1 Kings 4:26

- 4,000 stalls: The number 4,000 matches the text in 2 Chronicles 9:25, which is a suitable amount for Solomon's 1,400 chariots (1 Kings 10:26; 2 Chronicles 1:14).
- 12,000 horses: The Hebrew word can mean "horsemen" (Exodus 15:19–21) or "horses" (Joel 2:4). To prepare for battles, Solomon built towns to house his forces (1 Kings 9:19).

1 Kings 4:29–30

men of the East: Babylon was famous for its wise men. However, Solomon's wisdom, given by God (1 Kings 3:9, 12, 28; Proverbs 1:7; Ecclesiastes 12:13), was greater than all of them (1 Kings 4:34).

1 Kings 4:31

- Ethan and Heman were musicians chosen by David (see 1 Chronicles 6:33–47; 15:16–19; Psalms 88, 89).
- The sons of Mahol were Temple singers. So Heman, Calcol, and Darda likely took part in worship services (see 1 Chronicles 15:17, 19–22).

1 Kings 4:32–34

proverbs ... songs: Solomon wrote much of the book of Proverbs and composed Psalms 72 and 127. His knowledge of plants and animals showed his careful observation of nature (see Proverbs 6:6–8). Solomon's wisdom and literary skill (see Matthew 12:42) are evident in the Song of Songs and Ecclesiastes. It is no surprise that many, including kings (1 Kings 10:1–9), sought Solomon's wisdom.

1 Kings 5:1–18

King Hiram of Tyre was a loyal friend of David (2 Samuel 5:11–12). This likely means they had a treaty. Hiram was an important ally and business partner (1 Kings 5:7–11, 18; 9:11, 26–28; 10:22). His name is a shorter version of Ahiram, found in other Phoenician writings.

1 Kings 5:2–6

Solomon sent a message to Hiram through his ambassadors. He said he planned to build a temple to honor the name of the Lord. This followed the desire of his father David, who had already made plans and gathered materials for its construction (2 Samuel 7:1–3; 1 Chronicles 17:1–15; 22:14–19; 28:9–12).

1 Kings 5:3

put his enemies under his feet: In the Ancient Near East, inscriptions and paintings often show victorious

kings standing on the necks of defeated enemies or with enemies lying at their feet.

1 Kings 5:4–5

- Unlike David, Solomon had peace [literally rest] on all sides. Solomon's name (Hebrew shlomoh) might be a version of the word for "peace" (Hebrew shalom).
- The name of the Lord represents God's revealed character and reputation. The Hebrew term translated as the name was sometimes used when reading Scripture aloud to avoid saying God's personal name (the tetragrammaton—YHWH). The New Testament uses the term "the name" to refer to Jesus (Acts 5:41; 3 John 1:7).

1 Kings 5:6

- Solomon's main message was his request for cedars from Lebanon, showing Hiram's broad commercial influence. Ancient Near Eastern writings often mention using Lebanese cedars to build and furnish temples and palaces.
- Sidonians was a general term for Phoenicians. Sidon was older than Tyre.

1 Kings 5:7

Blessed be the LORD: Hiram did not worship Israel's God, but he respectfully acknowledged Solomon's God, following ancient customs (see 1 Kings 10:9; 2 Kings 18:22–25; Ezra 1:2–4; 6:12; Daniel 2:47; 3:29; 6:26–27).

1 Kings 5:7–12

Hiram's response to Solomon confirmed and continued the friendly relations he had with David. The partnership benefited both sides. Solomon got the construction materials he needed for the temple. In return, he provided necessities for Hiram's household (1 Kings 5:9–10) and paid Hiram's workers (1 Kings 5:6). This passage shows the Phoenicians' skill in business and Solomon's great wealth. It also highlights Solomon's wisdom, which he believed was a gift from God. The mainly business-focused venture led to a formal peace alliance (1 Kings 5:12).

1 Kings 5:13

Foreigners who lived permanently in Israel made up most of Solomon's labor force. Israelites themselves usually served only as temporary supervisors for Solomon's building projects (1 Kings 9:22–23; 11:28).

1 Kings 5:13–18

This passage explains Solomon's workforce and how they divided the work. Forced labor was common in the ancient Near East (see study note on 1 Kings 4:6).

1 Kings 5:16

3,300 foremen: In 2 Chronicles (2 Chronicles 2:2, 17–18; 8:10), there are 3,600 non-Israelite foremen and 250 Israelite chief supervisors. In the Hebrew text of 1 Kings 5:16 and 9:23, the numbers are 3,300 foremen and 550 chief supervisors. It is possible that 250 of the chief supervisors were Israelites, and 300 non-Israelites held the same rank.

1 Kings 5:17–18

Workers likely cut large, high-quality stone blocks to size (see 1 Kings 7:10) in a quarry near Jerusalem (6:7). Handling these massive stones probably led Solomon to start using forced labor. The craftsmen included men from Gebal (Byblos), a port known for exporting timber, according to ancient Egyptian inscriptions.

1 Kings 6:1

Solomon's fourth year as king was about 967 BC. If the number 480 in the Bible is taken as actual calendar years, then Israel's exodus from Egypt would have happened about 1446 BC. Others understand the number as symbolic, meaning 12 generations of 40 years each. This view places the exodus later, around 1270 BC (see Exodus Book Introduction, "The Date of the Exodus").

1 Kings 6:1–8.66

The construction of the Temple and palace complex, along with the temple's dedication celebration, are key events in the 1 Kings account of Solomon's time. The temple, built to honor God, was Israel's most important building. Therefore, the writer of 1 Kings documented its construction details thoroughly.

1 Kings 6:2

Like the tabernacle before it, the temple (literally house) was where God met with his people. David had gathered materials for its construction (1 Chronicles 22:2–4, 14) and had created plans for the temple, which he gave to Solomon (1 Chronicles 28:11–12). The temple's floor plan was similar to the tabernacle's but was twice as long and wide, and taller (compare Exodus 26:3, 15–30; 36:26–34).

1 Kings 6:3–4

Unlike the tabernacle, the temple had an entry room (or porch) on the east side and two freestanding pillars in front of the entrance (1 Kings 7:15–22).

1 Kings 6:11–13

The Lord had an encouraging message for Solomon. Since God appeared to Solomon before (1 Kings 3:5) and after (1 Kings 9:2) this event, a prophet likely delivered this word. The message reminded the king of God's earlier promise (1 Kings 3:14): If Solomon stayed faithful to God, the temple he was building would become God's eternal home.

1 Kings 6:14–35

The focus shifts to the inside of the temple. Although the temple site is not mentioned here, the Chronicler identified it as the former threshing floor of Araunah (1 Chronicles 21:18–25; 2 Chronicles 3:1). This site is traditionally believed to be Mount Moriah (Genesis 22:2). Solomon's Temple was in the northeastern corner of Jerusalem, now known as the "old city." This is the area now associated with the Dome of the Rock.

1 Kings 6:15–18

cedar paneling: The interior walls were covered with cedar wood from floor to ceiling, hiding all exterior stones. This created a stunning and carefully crafted look, showing great expense.

1 Kings 6:19–22

- The inner sanctuary of the temple, following the tabernacle's design, was covered inside with solid gold. A curtain (2 Chronicles 3:14) and gold chains separated it from the main room. Like the Most Holy Place in the tabernacle, the inner sanctuary was a perfect cube. It held the ark of the covenant of the LORD, symbolizing God's presence. The place of atonement was on top of the ark (Exodus 25:17), where the high priest sprinkled sacrificial blood each year to atone for the Israelites (Leviticus 16:1–19).
- The altar for the Most Holy Place was in the main room, where priests burned incense daily (Exodus 30:34–38; 37:25–29). The altar was made of cedar and covered with gold.
- Like the inner sanctuary, the main room was also fully covered with gold, reminding priests of God's presence. The main room contained ten golden lampstands, ten tables (2 Chronicles 4:7–8), and other furnishings (1 Kings 7:48–50).

1 Kings 6:23–28

In the inner sanctuary were two cherubim (see study note on 1 Chronicles 28:18) made of olive wood and covered with gold. They stood like guards facing the door (2 Chronicles 3:13), and their wings together stretched from wall to wall. Along with the two smaller cherubim facing each other on top of the ark (Exodus 25:17–21), they represented the powerful presence of the Most Holy God.

1 Kings 6:36–38

The inner courtyard around the temple was only for priests (2 Chronicles 4:9). It had the bronze altar (2 Chronicles 4:1), the bronze Sea (1 Kings 7:23–26; 2 Chronicles 4:2–5), and ten carts. Each cart could hold a basin of water for purification (1 Kings 7:27–40; 2 Chronicles 4:6).

1 Kings 6:38

In his eleventh year and eighth month, the month of Bul: The year was 960 BC.

1 Kings 7:1–12

Before describing the temple's furnishings, the writer talks about the construction of Solomon's palace complex. Building this complex took almost twice as long (thirteen years) as building the temple (seven years, 1 Kings 6:38). The entire project lasted twenty years (1 Kings 9:10). Although construction details are brief, archaeological finds of two of Solomon's buildings give us an idea of the palace's appearance. Despite its grandeur, Solomon's palace is not the main focus; the author is more interested in the temple, where God resides.

1 Kings 7:2–5

The House of the Forest of Lebanon got its name because it used a lot of cedar wood. It held 300 gold shields (1 Kings 10:16–17) and likely served as both a treasury and an armory (see 1 Kings 12:25–28; Isaiah 22:8). The Egyptian pharaoh Shishak later took the shields as loot (1 Kings 14:27).

1 Kings 7:6–8

- There was a columned entrance to the Hall of Justice, where Solomon listened to legal cases (see also 1 Kings 10:18–20). Similar throne rooms have been discovered in Syria and Mesopotamia.
- Solomon built separate living quarters for Pharaoh's daughter (see 1 Kings 3:1; 9:24; 2 Chronicles 8:11).

1 Kings 7:9–11

Like the temple, Solomon's palace used high-quality stones that were precisely cut and trimmed. Similar stonework has been discovered at Megiddo. Cedar beams between the wall layers helped protect against earthquakes.

1 Kings 7:12

The large courtyard around the temple and palace complex served as a gathering place for the people (see Jeremiah 7:1–2; 36:10).

1 Kings 7:13–14

- Huram: Like his father, he was an expert craftsman in bronze and other materials (2 Chronicles 2:12–14). The following verses describe his skillful metal work (1 Kings 7:15–50).
- great skill, understanding, and knowledge: The Israelites valued practical skills and saw them as a form of wisdom (Proverbs 22:29).

1 Kings 7:15–22

The two bronze pillars were likely free-standing because the narrator mentions them here instead of during the earlier discussion of the temple structure (1 Kings 6:3–6).

1 Kings 7:23–26

The large bronze basin, known as the Sea, replaced the smaller bronze washbasin used in the tabernacle (see Exodus 30:17–21). The Sea was made as one solid piece, except for the twelve bronze oxen it rested on. These oxen faced in four directions, three per direction, possibly symbolizing the priests' service to all twelve tribes of Israel. Later, Ahaz replaced the oxen with a stone base (2 Kings 16:17). Like the earlier washbasin, priests used the Sea for ceremonial washing (2 Chronicles 4:6) as they prepared to serve God (see Exodus 30:17–21). The difference in its water capacity (see 2 Chronicles 4:5) likely comes from varying measurement standards over time and place.

1 Kings 7:27–39

The ten bronze water carts each held a basin for washing burnt offerings (2 Chronicles 4:6). Five were on each side of the temple. They had wheels, so they could be moved when needed.

1 Kings 7:40–45

Huram was very skilled at making items of different sizes and complexities. He also created the bronze altar for the inner court, which was used for burnt offerings (2 Chronicles 4:1).

1 Kings 7:46–47

between Succoth and Zarethan: This area east of the Jordan River (see Joshus 3:16; Judges 8:4–5) was famous for metalworking. It had plenty of clay for molds, wood for fuel, and a strong north wind that helped with casting.

1 Kings 7:48–49

The gold altar replaced the incense-burning altar used in the tabernacle (Exodus 30:1–10). In the temple, ten tables and ten lampstands replaced the single table and lampstand from the tabernacle (Exodus 25:23–40). One gold table for the Bread of the Presence is mentioned. But the author of Chronicles notes ten tables, five on each side of the temple's main room (2 Chronicles 4:8), along with ten solid gold lampstands. The bread symbolized God's provision for his people, and the lampstand represented God as the source of life and truth. Both symbols pointed to Christ, the bread of life (John 6:35) and the light of the world (John 8:12).

1 Kings 7:50–51

The writer highlights Solomon's extensive use of gold to furnish the temple. David and the people gathered a large amount of gold for the temple (1 Chronicles 29:1–9). Solomon also collected gold each year (1 Kings 10:14), so he always had plenty available (see 1 Kings 10:21).

1 Kings 8:1

The ark was kept in a tent in the City of David (2 Samuel 6:3–17; 1 Chronicles 13:7–14; 15:1–16:43). Solomon had visited earlier to offer sacrifices after God appeared to him in a dream in Gibeon (1 Kings 3:4–15).

1 Kings 8:1–66

Solomon's building efforts peaked when he moved the ark to the new temple. The king prayed (1 Kings 8:22–53) and offered praise and blessings (8:56–61) to dedicate the temple to the Lord. After the dedication, the people celebrated the Feast of Tabernacles. The story highlights Solomon praising God and blessing the people (1 Kings 8:12–61).

1 Kings 8:2

Although the temple was finished in the eighth month (1 Kings 6:38), Solomon waited until the next year to dedicate it. He chose the annual Feast of Tabernacles

in early autumn, during the month of Ethanim. This timing allowed for a grand celebration and added extra meaning to the event.

According to the law, Solomon and the people thanked God for the harvest. They also celebrated the promise from the song of Moses that God would settle his people in the promised land and live there (Exodus 15:17; Deuteronomy 12:10–14). Solomon's prayer and blessing suggest he was guiding his people in renewing their covenant with God, as outlined in Deuteronomy 31:10–13, during the seventh month of the seventh year of his reign.

1 Kings 8:3–4

The priests and Levites carried the ark of the LORD as the law instructed (Exodus 25:14–15; Numbers 4:5–8; compare 2 Samuel 6:1–15).

1 Kings 8:5

The Israelites made countless sacrifices, showing both joy and seriousness during this event.

1 Kings 8:8

According to the law (Exodus 25:15), the carrying poles had to stay with the ark.

1 Kings 8:9

The emphasis on the two stone tablets that Moses put in the ark (see 1 Kings 8:21; Exodus 25:21; Deuteronomy 31:26) suggests Solomon was thinking about renewing the covenant of Moses and dedicating the temple.

1 Kings 8:10–11

When the priests left the Holy Place, music welcomed them, praising the Lord (2 Chronicles 5:11–14). Before, God's glorious presence filled the tabernacle (Exodus 40:34–35). Now, it filled the temple, showing God was with his people again. Ezekiel noted when God's presence later left the temple (Ezekiel 10:18–19) and predicted its return in a blessed future (Ezekiel 43:1–5).

In the New Testament, John wrote that God lives among his people through Jesus Christ (John 1:14). Paul confirmed that Christ now lives in each believer (Colossians 1:27) as a preview of a future when "the dwelling place of God is with man" (Revelation 21:3).

1 Kings 8:12–13

thick cloud: Solomon saw the cloud filling the inner sanctuary as a sign of God's presence. However, he knew that God could not be confined to a human-made temple (see 1 Kings 8:27). Solomon completed his task to build the temple (1 Kings 8:19; 1 Chronicles 28:10), trusting the promises that God would live in the sanctuary (see Exodus 15:17).

1 Kings 8:12–21

Solomon started with a prayer (1 Kings 8:12–13), then blessed the people and praised God for keeping his promises (8:14–21). Like many praise psalms, Solomon honored God, humbled himself, and spoke of God's great goodness.

1 Kings 8:14–16

Solomon praised God for keeping his promises and blessing his people (see 2 Samuel 7:12–16; compare 2 Chronicles 6:1–11).

1 Kings 8:22

As Solomon prayed, he lifted his hands toward heaven and knelt before the Lord on a platform in clear view of the congregation (1 Kings 8:54; 2 Chronicles 6:13). Jesus criticized people who pretended to be religious without true belief (Matthew 6:5–8). But Solomon's public devotion was sincere, leading his people in worship and encouraging them to rely fully on God. A nation that knows and obeys the Lord, and whose leaders rule justly, is especially blessed (2 Chronicles 7:14; Psalms 33:12; 45:6–7; 144:15; Proverbs 29:2; Isaiah 11:1–5).

1 Kings 8:22–61

Solomon's prayer of dedication for the temple praised God and blessed the people. He highlighted God's faithfulness to His promises and his own part in building the temple. Solomon prayed for God to keep answering their prayers (1 Kings 8:22–30). He then made seven specific requests to God (1 Kings 8:31–53) and ended with a blessing (1 Kings 8:54–61).

1 Kings 8:23–26

Solomon's prayer highlighted God's unique nature and how he kept his promises to David. Solomon also asked God to ensure that David's descendants would always rule on the throne.

1 Kings 8:29–51

Solomon asked God to listen to his people's prayers from the temple. He mentioned specific situations where they would need God's help.

1 Kings 8:31–32

Solomon asked God to make the right decision and ensure justice in court cases when there were no

witnesses to prove innocence (see Exodus 22:7–12). Solomon might have understood that future officials would not have the special wisdom God gave him (1 Kings 3:12; for example, 3:16–27).

1 Kings 8:33–34

Solomon asked about future times when the people of Israel sinned and God let their enemies defeat them (see Leviticus 26:14–17; Deuteronomy 28:15, 25–26, 45, 49; Joshua 7). He asked that if the people truly repented, God would honor his promise and forgive them (Leviticus 26:39–42).

1 Kings 8:35–36

Solomon prayed about drought caused by the people's sins (Leviticus 26:19; Deuteronomy 28:23–24). He asked that if the people confessed and truly repented, God would forgive them and make the land fertile again. This way, the people would learn to live righteously before God.

1 Kings 8:37–40

Solomon prayed about disasters caused by personal or group sin (Leviticus 26:16, 19–26; Deuteronomy 28:21–22, 38–40, 42, 58–61). Solomon asked that if God's people confessed and truly repented, God would act fairly so everyone could live with respect for him (Deuteronomy 8:6; 2 Chronicles 7:14; Proverbs 1:7; 9:10; 15:33).

1 Kings 8:41–43

Solomon wanted people who were not Israelites to respect the Lord and have a relationship with him. He understood that Israel needed to show the Lord's true nature to those not part of the covenant (see Genesis 12:7; Psalm 102:15; Habakkuk 2:14; Matthew 28:19).

1 Kings 8:44–45

Solomon asked God to listen to the prayers of those who could not reach the temple, especially those far away fighting for God's cause (Leviticus 26:7–8; Deuteronomy 20:1–4). He wanted God to hear their prayers directed toward the Lord and his temple in Jerusalem (see Daniel 6:10).

1 Kings 8:46–51

Solomon prayed about a future time when Israel might be taken captive (Leviticus 26:33). He asked that if the people truly repented and admitted their sins, God would listen, forgive them, and help them find favor with their captors (Leviticus 26:40–45; 2 Kings 25:27–30; Daniel 6:10; 9:3–19).

1 Kings 8:52–53

Solomon ended his prayer of dedication by asking God to be available to all of Israel and to answer their prayers. Referring back to when God brought the Israelites out of Egypt (1 Kings 8:16), Solomon reminded God that he chose Israel as his special people (Exodus 19:5; Deuteronomy 7:6; 14:1–2; 26:18; Psalm 135:4; see also Titus 2:11–14; 1 Peter 2:9–10).

1 Kings 8:54–56

Solomon praised God's faithfulness and goodness to Israel for giving them rest as promised (see Joshua 21:43–45; 23:14; 2 Samuel 7:1). Some Israelites did not accept the rest that only God provides (Psalm 95:10–11; Hebrews 3:7–19; 4:1–11).

1 Kings 8:57–61

Solomon asked God to stay with his people and help them become obedient and faithful. With God's grace and their faithfulness, Israel could experience God's justice and show everyone that the Lord alone is God.

1 Kings 8:62–66

The final sacrifices (see Deuteronomy 12:5–14) and the Feast of Tabernacles end the story that began with sacrifices when the ark was placed in the Most Holy Place (1 Kings 8:1–11; compare 2 Chronicles 7:1–6).

1 Kings 8:65

- Lebo-hamath in the north of Aram and the Brook of Egypt (called Wadi al Arish) in the south marked the borders of the promised land (Joshua 13:5; 15:4).
- kept the feast before the LORD our God for seven days and seven more days: After the dedication, the feast lasted another seven days.

1 Kings 9:2

The Lord had appeared to Solomon before, granting him wisdom (1 Kings 3:3–15). The author of Chronicles adds more details about God's blessings or judgment, based on the faithfulness of Solomon and Israel (2 Chronicles 7:11–22).

1 Kings 9:3–9

The Lord responded to Solomon's prayer by explaining the covenant's conditions. Obedience would lead to prosperity and blessings, while disobedience could cause disaster, including the city's and temple's destruction and the people's exile (see Deuteronomy 28:36–37, 63–68). Although God's covenant was unchangeable, enjoying its blessings required faithfulness to its terms (Psalm 89:24–37).

1 Kings 9:10–14

Solomon made a business deal with King Hiram, trading wheat and olive oil for timber and gold (1 Kings 5:10–11). When Solomon owed Hiram, he gave him twenty towns in Galilee as payment. However, Hiram was unhappy with the towns and returned them to Solomon (see 2 Chronicles 8:2). The two friends agreed on other compensation and continued as allies and trading partners (1 Kings 9:26–28; 10:22).

1 Kings 9:15

Solomon strengthened the supporting terraces on a slope of the southeastern ridge in the traditional City of David area of Jerusalem (see 2 Samuel 5:9) and the wall of Jerusalem. He also fortified the important cities of Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer.

Archaeological research shows that the walls and gates of all three cities have unique features from Solomon's time. Hazor, in the north, served as a first line of defense against invasion. Megiddo, in the Plain of Sharon, also had important military significance (2 Kings 23:29–30; Revelation 16:12–16).

1 Kings 9:15–24

Solomon used forced labor to finish many construction projects (1 Kings 4:6; 5:13–18; 9:20–23; 12:4, 18–19; compare 1 Samuel 8:10–18).

1 Kings 9:16

Gezer, located west of Jerusalem, was not originally settled by the Israelites. An Egyptian pharaoh conquered it and gave it to his daughter as a wedding gift when she married Solomon. An inscription in the Amon Temple in Tanis seems to show a victory by Pharaoh Siamun of the 21st dynasty, who ruled from 978 to 959 BC, against the Philistines, suggesting Siamun was the pharaoh involved.

1 Kings 9:17–18

Lower Beth-horon was an important defense site for western Judah. Several cities in Canaan were called Baalath; the one here was likely also known as Kiriath-jearim (see 2 Samuel 6:2; Joshua 15:9; 1 Chronicles 13:5, 6). Tamar was probably located in the southeastern part of the Holy Land (see Ezekiel 47:19; 48:28).

1 Kings 9:20–23

Solomon's conscripted workers included early Canaanite settlers. There were 550 chief supervisors, and 250 of them were Israelites, overseeing the laborers (2 Chronicles 8:9–10; see 1 Kings 5:15–16 with 2 Chronicles 2:17–18).

1 Kings 9:21

devote to destruction: See "Complete Dedication" Theme Note.

1 Kings 9:24

Solomon built a new palace for Pharaoh's daughter, separate from his own, because his palace was considered holy. The ark of the LORD had been there (2 Chronicles 8:11). The ark's location was sacred, as it represented God's presence and made the area holy (Exodus 25:22; see also 2 Samuel 6:7; 1 Chronicles 15:11–13).

1 Kings 9:25

Three times a year, Solomon showed great leadership for Israel by offering sacrifices at the national festivals of:

- Unleavened Bread,
- Weeks (also called Pentecost or Harvest), and
- Tabernacles (Deuteronomy 16:16).

1 Kings 9:26–28

The seaport of Ezion-geber was on the Gulf of Aqaba, which connects to the Red Sea. The exact location of Ophir is unknown, but it might have been in southwestern Arabia, eastern Africa, or India. The mention of gold and other valuable goods (see 1 Kings 10:11–12) highlights its importance for trade.

1 Kings 10:1

- The queen probably heard about Solomon's wisdom and wealth because of his trade trips to Ophir (1 Kings 10:11; see 1 Kings 9:26–28). Sheba, in southwestern Arabia (modern Yemen), was a fertile trade center. The ancient Sabeans traded across vast areas, including Syria, Africa, and India.
- test ... with difficult questions (literally riddles): Arabian literature is known for its riddles and proverbs. The queen tested Solomon's wisdom and explored her own mysteries.

1 Kings 10:1–13

The queen of Sheba visited to see if the stories about Solomon's wisdom were true (1 Kings 10:1, 3, 6–7). She might have also been interested in trade partnerships (1 Kings 10:2, 10, 13). Solomon achieved everything because of his wisdom from God, as the queen of Sheba confirms in her main speech (1 Kings 10:6–9).

1 Kings 10:2

The queen of Sheba came as a royal guest, with a large group and camels carrying valuable goods. This was an important meeting, shown by Solomon's generous gifts to her (1 Kings 10:13).

1 Kings 10:3–5

The queen was impressed by Solomon's wisdom. He answered her questions well, and she admired his wise building projects, organized administration, and dedication to his God. Jesus praised the queen for seeking truth but criticized the Pharisees and religious teachers for not recognizing him, who was greater than Solomon (Matthew 12:42).

1 Kings 10:6–9

The queen's testimony showed her amazement. Everything she heard was true, and seeing it herself, she realized Solomon's achievements were even greater. She understood that the Lord supported Solomon and that Solomon should use his God-given wisdom to lead with fairness and justice.

1 Kings 10:10–12

- Solomon had a lot of gold during his reign. The queen's gifts added to what Solomon already had from his trade with Hiram of Tyre. He used the gold wisely (see 1 Kings 6:20–22, 28, 30, 32, 35; 7:49–51; 10:18, 21).
- Arabian traders sold spices like frankincense and myrrh. Both were used for medicine; frankincense was also used in holy incense (Exodus 30:34–38; Leviticus 2:2), and myrrh was used for perfume and embalming the dead. Wise men from the east gave these spices and gold to Jesus (Matthew 2:1–11).

1 Kings 10:11

Sandalwood is a reddish-brown wood from India, prized for its fragrant essential oil. Ancient tablets from Ras Shamra and Alalakh show it was also valued for making high-quality furniture and musical instruments.

1 Kings 10:13

whatever she asked: Solomon, as a royal host, gave her gifts in return. Solomon and the queen of Sheba likely formed a trade agreement. Later stories from Jewish, Arabian, and Ethiopian cultures about a romance between them are not based on facts.

1 Kings 10:14–15

666 talents (about 25 tons): Solomon got this large amount of gold from his businesses and taxes. He also charged tolls to merchants and traders passing through his kingdom.

1 Kings 10:14–29

To show more of Solomon's greatness, the writer adds to the story of the queen's visit (1 Kings 10:1–13). The writer describes Solomon's wise use of wealth in building his palace complex (10:14–21). The writer then tells how Solomon's wisdom also brought wide influence through his trade and commercial dealings (10:22–29).

1 Kings 10:16–17

Normally, large shields were made for foot soldiers and small shields for archers. But these shields were probably used for ceremonies instead of battle.

1 Kings 10:18–21

Solomon got ivory by trading with Hiram. Kings in the Ancient Near East often used lion figures to show royal power and to symbolize divine protection of the throne.

1 Kings 10:22

- the ships of Tarshish: This Hebrew term refers to a type of merchant ship.
- Phoenician sailors operated Solomon's fleet, which sailed from Ezion-geber (1 Kings 9:26–28; see Isaiah 23:1).
- apes, and peacocks: Archaeology shows that kings imported these animals. They were valued for their novelty, exotic nature, and as symbols of conquering distant lands.

1 Kings 10:26

1,400 chariots: Before Solomon, chariots were not a major part of Israel's army. Deuteronomy 17:16 warns kings against gathering horses instead of trusting God. While some debate the archaeological evidence of chariots in Solomon's time, his chariot cities are often thought to be b Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer (1 Kings 9:15, 19). The Assyrian king Shalmaneser III mentioned facing many enemy chariots at the Battle of Qarqar in 853 BC, with 2,000 provided by King Ahab of Israel.

1 Kings 10:28–29

Solomon also acted as a trader, exchanging horses and chariots between the Egyptians in the south and the Syrians and Anatolians in the north.

1 Kings 11:1–3

Despite his wisdom from God, Solomon disobeyed the law of Moses by amassing wealth and marrying many wives (see Exodus 34:12–17; Deuteronomy 7:3–4; 17:17). He married to form alliances with other nations, which weakened his spiritual dedication and led him away from God. This had severe spiritual and political effects on his people (see 1 Kings 11:4–13; 12:4, 16; 2 Kings 17:5–23; 25:1–23).

1 Kings 11:4–8

he did not follow the LORD completely: David committed a serious sin, but he truly repented when God's prophet confronted him (2 Samuel 11:1–12:23; Psalm 51:1–4). However, Solomon ignored God's warnings (1 Kings 3:14; 6:12–13; 9:4–9) and did not learn from Israel's history. Instead, he repeated their sins.

1 Kings 11:5

- Ashtoreth was the Canaanite goddess of love and war. She was widely worshiped in the ancient Near East. She was also known as Ishtar and Astarte. The worship practices of Astarte influenced the Greek worship of the goddess Aphrodite.
- The worship of Molech, the god of the Ammonites, involved sacrificing children by fire (1 Kings 11:7; see Leviticus 20:1–5; 2 Kings 16:3; 23:5–10; Jeremiah 7:30–33; 19:4–6; 32:35). The writer strongly condemns these practices as detestable.

1 Kings 11:7

The Moabite god Chemosh is mentioned on the Mesha Stela (Moabite Stone), which describes the conflict between Moab and Israel (see 2 Kings 3).

1 Kings 11:9–10

The LORD ... had appeared to him twice (1 Kings 3:5–15; 9:1–9): Each time, God reminded Solomon to stay faithful. When Solomon ignored God's warning about worshiping other gods, he broke the first commandment (Exodus 20:3) and God's agreements with Moses and David.

1 Kings 11:11–13

God declared that the kingdom would split, but Solomon's descendants would keep a portion of it (see 1 Kings 11:32–36).

1 Kings 11:14–22

Solomon's first enemy was Hadad. David had fought the Edomites and defeated them severely (2 Samuel 8:13–14; 1 Chronicles 18:13Œ14). Hadad was the only survivor from the Edomite royal family. He escaped to Egypt with some followers. The Egyptian king welcomed him as a possible ally and gave him his wife's sister to marry. When David and Joab died, Hadad returned to Edom, waiting for a chance to strike back at Israel.

1 Kings 11:14–40

God delivered Solomon's punishment through three political adversaries, Hadad, Rezon, and Jeroboam (see 1 Kings 11:40).

1 Kings 11:23–25

Solomon's second enemy was Rezon, an Aramean who had served under King Hadadezer of Aram-zobah. After David defeated Hadadezer (2 Samuel 8:3–7), Rezon escaped, gathered followers, and went to Damascus. He stayed there when Solomon campaigned in Hamath-zobah (2 Chronicles 8:3–4) and eventually became king of Damascus. Like Hadad, Rezon was a persistent enemy of Israel and caused trouble for Solomon.

1 Kings 11:26–40

Details about Solomon's third enemy, Jeroboam son of Nebat, help explain how the kingdom of Israel split (1 Kings 12–14).

1 Kings 11:27–28

Solomon noticed Jeroboam's strong work ethic during the city's repairs and put him in charge. Jeroboam's position among the workers likely made him aware of growing unrest in the northern parts of Solomon's kingdom. Jeroboam showed leadership during this time and when the empire split and the northern tribes reorganized (1 Kings 12:12–19, 25–33). Unfortunately, he did not always use his skills wisely and later proved unfaithful to the Lord (1 Kings 12:25–13:10; 14:14–16; 2 Kings 17:21–23).

1 Kings 11:29–32

Ahijah tore his cloak into twelve pieces and gave ten to Jeroboam. This act showed God's plans for Jeroboam and Israel after Solomon's death (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note). Ten tribes would leave, while one tribe, Judah, would stay with Solomon's heir. The twelfth tribe was likely Benjamin (see 1 Kings 12:21). Benjamin often acted with Judah (see 2 Chronicles 11:3, 23; 14:8; 15:2–9; 17:17). Simeon,

another southern tribe, seems to have joined the north (2 Chronicles 15:9; 34:6).

1 Kings 11:29–39

The meeting between Jeroboam and the prophet Ahijah started God's judgment on Solomon's family line. Ahijah appears again in the story of Jeroboam's sick son (1 Kings 14:1–18). He wrote a book, now lost, that included details about Solomon's actions (2 Chronicles 9:29).

1 Kings 11:34

for the sake of David: Even though Solomon broke God's agreement, God kept his promises to David (see also Psalm 89:28–37).

1 Kings 11:34–39

Ahijah also told about the coming division of the kingdom. He gave God's message to Jeroboam: God would bless him and give him lasting rule if he obeyed the Lord.

1 Kings 11:36

a lamp: David's successors were to be living symbols of God's promise to David. They were to shine as examples of God's grace (1 Kings 15:4; 2 Kings 8:19; 2 Chronicles 21:7). They pointed to Jesus, David's descendant, who is the light of the world (John 1:4–5) and fulfills God's promises to David (Ezekiel 34:23–31).

1 Kings 11:38

a lasting dynasty: A dynasty is a family line of rulers, where a king's descendants (sons and grandsons) continue to rule after him. Jeroboam had a great opportunity. God promised that if he was faithful and obeyed the Lord, his kingdom would last for a long time. But Jeroboam turned away from God (1 Kings 12:25–33; 14:10–18). He led Israel onto a harmful spiritual path that later brought destruction (2 Kings 17:21–23).

1 Kings 11:39

Jesus, a descendant of David, would later inherit his rightful throne, as promised by God to:

- David (2 Samuel 7:13, 16–19; Psalm 89:35–37),
- Abraham (Genesis 17:1–8; Luke 1:67–79), and
- Judah (Genesis 49:10).

He has made a new agreement with God's people and will rule forever (Jeremiah 31:31–36; Ezekiel 37:22–28; 2 Corinthians 3:6).

1 Kings 11:40

- Solomon likely knew trouble was coming. So he attempted to kill Jeroboam.
- Later, King Shishak of Egypt invaded Judah when Solomon's son Rehoboam was king (1 Kings 14:25–26).

1 Kings 11:41–43

- The brief summary of Solomon's reign and death is similar to that of his father David (1 Kings 2:10–12). These summaries follow a typical pattern for the accounts of later kings.
- The Book of the Acts of Solomon was probably kept in a prophetic center or in palace and Temple archives. It provided information for the author of Kings but is now lost (compare 1 Kings 14:19, 29).
- Solomon ruled from 971 to 931 BC.

1 Kings 12:1

- Shechem was in the center of the northern tribes' land. It was a key site and religious center even before the Israelites occupied Canaan (Genesis 12:6–7; 33:18–20). It became significant in Israel as a Levitical city and a city of refuge (Joshua 20:7; 21:20; 24:1). Rehoboam knew he needed the northern tribes' approval and support to rule a united kingdom. Shechem later became the temporary capital of the northern kingdom (1 Kings 12:25).
- Rehoboam ruled from 931 to 913 BC.

1 Kings 12:4

the burden of your father's service and the heavy yoke: See 1 Kings 4:7, 22–23; 5:13–18; 9:20–23; 11:27–28.

1 Kings 12:5

three days: Rehoboam waited three days to consult his advisers, which was a traditional practice. The third day was often when final decisions were made (see 2 Kings 20:4–8). Jesus also rose from the grave on the third day (Luke 24:41; 1 Corinthians 15:4).

1 Kings 12:6–7

the elders: They had served under Solomon advised a moderate approach.

1 Kings 12:8–10

young men: Rehoboam's peers took a strict stance and advised against the older men's suggestions.

1 Kings 12:11

scorpions: This was likely a type of whip with barbs or nails. The wounds from this weapon felt like a scorpion's sting.

1 Kings 12:12–17

- Rehoboam listened to his younger advisers, which was a terrible choice. It caused the northern tribes to break away, leading to years of on-and-off fighting (1 Kings 14:30; 15:7, 32).
- from the LORD: God guided these decisions to carry out the predicted judgment against Solomon (1 Kings 11:11–13, 29Ý39).

1 Kings 12:18

Adoniram worked for both David (2 Samuel 20:24) and Solomon (1 Kings 4:6; 5:13–14). His death by stoning highlighted Rehoboam's mistake in sending the disliked labor supervisor to restore order in the north.

1 Kings 12:21–24

Rehoboam wanted to regain control of the kingdom by force, but he changed his mind after hearing God's message through Shemaiah. The phrase man of God highlights a prophet's role as God's messenger. Prophets were important in the history of the divided kingdom. Shemaiah likely wrote a history of Rehoboam's reign (2 Chronicles 12:15).

1 Kings 12:25

Both Shechem (1 Kings 12:1) and Peniel, which Jeroboam built across the Jordan River, were important defense sites against the Arameans.

1 Kings 12:25–33

Jeroboam's efforts to establish his kingdom are described in two parts. One part covers his construction projects (1 Kings 12:25), and the other discusses his false shrines and religious practices (1 Kings 12:26–33).

1 Kings 12:26–27

Jeroboam aimed to meet Israel's spiritual needs and keep his people's loyalty by making northern worship services easy and unique.

1 Kings 12:28

Two gold calves would resonate with Israel's history (see Exodus 32; especially 32:4). Similar religious practices linked to the Canaanite god Baal-Hadad also attracted the remaining Canaanite people in the northern kingdom. Jeroboam's actions undermined true worship and led to religious confusion (see 1 Kings 14:9; Hosea 8:6).

1 Kings 12:29–30

Jeroboam placed calf idols in Bethel (southern Israel) and Dan (northern Israel). These locations had long religious traditions (see Genesis 12:8; 28:11–19; Judges 18:30–31). Archaeologists found a high place, an altar for pagan worship, in Dan. Bethel was where Jacob dreamed (Genesis 28:10–22). It was also where the ark of the covenant rested during the time of the judges (Judges 20:18–28) and served as a sanctuary in Samuel's time (1 Samuel 7:16; 10:3).

1 Kings 12:31

Jeroboam broke the law of Moses by allowing worship at pagan shrines (Deuteronomy 12:2–7). The law also stated that priests should only be from the tribe of Levi (Exodus 40:13–15; Numbers 1:50–53).

1 Kings 12:32–33

- Replacing the Feast of Tabernacles, Israel's main ceremonial feast in the seventh month, with a festival in Bethel broke the law (Deuteronomy 16:13–15). Holding this imitation festival one month later in the eighth month might have matched the end of the Canaanite agricultural year. Jeroboam's false religious practices led to Israel's downfall (2 Kings 17:22).
- Jeroboam's offering of sacrifices on the altar at Bethel set a poor example in spiritual leadership.

1 Kings 13:1–10

The story of the unnamed man of God who spoke against Jeroboam's false altar at Bethel shows the authority of God's word. This prophecy even gave a personal name connected with an event that would happen much later (2 Kings 23:15–20).

Other examples are Isaiah's prophecy of Cyrus as a future ruler (Isaiah 44:28; 45:1) and Micah's prophecy that the Messiah would be born in Bethlehem (Micah 5:2). Prophecies like these give assurance that God is in control of history and knows all things (see Isaiah 42:9).

1 Kings 13:3

According to Levitical rules, ashes from sacrifices at the designated altar had to be taken to a clean place (Leviticus 1:16; 6:10–11). Jeroboam's altar split apart, causing its ashes to pour out, making the altar and its sacrifices unclean.

1 Kings 13:4–5

Jeroboam's shoulder and arm became paralyzed, and the prophecy about the altar came true. This showed God's power and his unhappiness with Jeroboam's false religion.

1 Kings 13:6

the king's hand was restored to him: God showed him mercy. This healing should have reminded Jeroboam that he could still serve God correctly.

1 Kings 13:7

refresh yourself: In ancient Near Eastern culture, when a king showed gratitude and offered hospitality, it also meant approval and friendship (1 Kings 13:19; see Genesis 24:52–54).

1 Kings 13:11–19

The old prophet had his reasons for finding the man of God, but he lied about getting a message from God through an angel. The man of God knew the old prophet's request went against God's instructions (1 Kings 13:8–10, 16–17; compare Galatians 1:8).

1 Kings 13:20–22

Even though the old prophet lied, God spoke through him. The harsh judgment against the man of God was that he would not be buried in his family tomb due to his disobedience. This punishment happened swiftly. Disobeying God's clear command is a serious offense (Numbers 14:21–23; Deuteronomy 11:26–28).

1 Kings 13:23–26

The donkey did not run away, and the lion did not eat the man's body. This was a supernatural event. The old prophet immediately understood that God had fulfilled his word by judging disobedience (1 Kings 13:21–22).

1 Kings 13:30

The old prophet likely had a simple grave. People carved these tombs out of soft limestone in a wadi (a dry stream bed) near their homes.

1 Kings 13:32

- the message ... will surely come to pass: The Lord's quick judgment convinced the old prophet that the prediction made by the man of God against Jeroboam's altar would happen. The prophecy was fulfilled years later during Josiah's reforms (2 Kings 23:15–18).
- Samaria became the capital city of Israel during Omri's reign, the first king of Israel's third dynasty (1 Kings 16:24, 29–33). The name Samaria sometimes refers to the capital city and sometimes to the northern kingdom as a whole (2 Kings 17:24; Amos 6:1). Mentioning Samaria here shows the viewpoint of an author from a later time. Similar uses of location names elsewhere show editorial updates (compare Genesis 23:2 with Joshua 14:15; Judges 1:10).

1 Kings 13:33–34

Jeroboam knew what happened to the man of God, but it did not change his beliefs. His continued false religion, despite God's warnings, led to the downfall of his family line (1 Kings 14:7–11, 15–16; 15:27–30). Later Israelite kings followed his sinful ways, which eventually caused the northern kingdom to collapse (2 Kings 17:20–23).

1 Kings 14:2

- disguise yourself: Jeroboam knew his wrongdoing kept him from approaching God's prophet. He understood that the prophet who foretold his rise to Israel's throne could also predict the child's future and possibly ask for God's help.
- Shiloh was destroyed by the Philistines during Eli's time (1 Samuel 4). Before that, the tabernacle was there (Joshua 18:1; 1 Samuel 1:3). A small community lived there again, but the area stayed mostly undeveloped during the divided kingdom.

1 Kings 14:3

People usually brought a gift to a prophet when asking for advice (2 Kings 5:5; 8:8). King Jeroboam's wife brought common items to help with her disguise.

1 Kings 14:5

You are to say such and such to her: The Lord often told prophets to share only the message he gave them (see 1 Kings 22:14; Numbers 22:38; 23:12; Jeremiah 7:2; Amos 7:14–15).

1 Kings 14:7

God blessed Jeroboam and made him ruler in Israel (see study note on 1 Kings 1:35). However, Jeroboam misused this position by creating a false religion.

1 Kings 14:8–9

- Unlike David, who truly repented for his sins (2 Samuel 12:13; Psalm 51:2–4), Jeroboam did more evil than those before him. Even with clear signs

of God's displeasure and warnings of judgment (1 Kings 13:33), he did not change his ways. His sins would lead to serious consequences for his family and descendants (1 Kings 13:34; 14:10–11, 14) and eventually affect the entire northern kingdom (14:16).
- molten images: see 1 Kings 12:26–30.

1 Kings 14:11

eaten by dogs: This warning of punishment for Jeroboam's family followed the legal curses for unfaithfulness (Deuteronomy 28:26; see 1 Kings 16:4; 21:23; 2 Kings 9:35–37).

1 Kings 14:14

cut off the house of Jeroboam: The prophecy came true quickly. God brought Baasha to power, and he killed Jeroboam's son Nadab in Nadab's second year as king (1 Kings 15:27–28).

1 Kings 14:15

People believed Asherah was the partner of El, the ancient Canaanite god. Worship of Asherah involved fertility rituals at sacred trees or poles. This practice became a recurring sin for God's people (1 Kings 15:13; 16:33; 18:19; Deuteronomy 16:21; Judges 3:7).

1 Kings 14:17–18

- Tirzah was located on the road from Shechem to Beth-shan. Known for its beauty (Song of Solomon 6:4), the city served as a royal retreat and became the capital of the northern kingdom (1 Kings 16:6, 8).
- The child died, as Ahijah had predicted.

1 Kings 14:19–20

- how he waged war: Jeroboam often fought border battles with Rehoboam (1 Kings 14:30).
- The Book of the History of the Kings of Israel is mentioned seventeen times in 1 Kings 14:19—2 Kings 15:31. It includes information that may have come from official records written by the court recorder (see 1 Kings 4:3). The original readers of 1–2 Kings knew this book, but it is now lost.

1 Kings 14:21

- Instead of any city in the northern kingdom the Lord chose Jerusalem.
- Naamah was the queen mother. She was highly respected in Judah. This role became an official position (1 Kings 15:13). Judah's queen mothers are often mentioned with the reigning king (see, for example, Jeremiah 22:26).

1 Kings 14:21–31

Between the start and end details of Rehoboam's rule (1 Kings 14:21, 29–31), the account highlights the declining spiritual state of God's people in Judah (1 Kings 14:22–24) and an invasion by Egypt (1 Kings 14:25–28).

1 Kings 14:22

Judah did evil: Although Rehoboam started his reign with good spiritual intentions (2 Chronicles 11:5–17, 23), he abandoned God's principles (2 Chronicles 12:1).

1 Kings 14:23–24

- Solomon married foreign wives, which led his family into idol worship. Under Rehoboam's leadership, Judah continued the offensive practices of the pagan nations that lived in the land before the Israelites. When leaders are corrupt, a nation's spiritual decline often follows, leading to shame and ruin (Proverbs 14:34).
- Shrine prostitutes were common in Canaan but were forbidden for Israel (see study notes on Leviticus 17:7; Deuteronomy 23:17–18). They became part of Israelite society as the people adopted Canaanite culture.

1 Kings 14:25

Shishak (also called Shoshenq I) ruled Egypt from 945–924 BC. He was the first king of Egypt's 22nd dynasty (family line of rulers). He reunited Egypt after it had been divided during the 21st dynasty. Under his rule, Egypt became stable again and grew in wealth and military strength. His attack on Judah is noted by the writer of Chronicles (2 Chronicles 12:2–4) and is written on the Amon Temple in Thebes.

1 Kings 14:26–28

When Rehoboam replaced Solomon's gold shields with bronze ones, it showed the kingdom's declining spiritual state. Judah and Jerusalem avoided complete destruction only after Rehoboam repented in response to the Lord's message through the prophet Shemaiah (2 Chronicles 12:5–6, 12).

1 Kings 14:29–31

The final report about Rehoboam's rule mentions his ongoing conflict with Jeroboam.

1 Kings 15:1

Abijam ruled from 913 to 910 BC (see study note on 2 Chronicles 13:1).

1 Kings 15:1–8

The author of 1 and 2 Kings describes each king of Judah's rule in a set pattern:

1. The date he became king, compared to the current king of the other kingdom (1 Kings 15:1).
2. How long he ruled (1 Kings 15:2).
3. His mother's name (1 Kings 15:2).
4. A spiritual judgment about his character (1 Kings 15:3–5).
5. Important events from his reign (1 Kings 15:6–7).
6. A note about other records where more information could be found (1 Kings 15:7).
7. Where he was buried (1 Kings 15:8).
8. The name of the next king (1 Kings 15:8).

1 Kings 15:2

Abijam's mother was Maacah. Maacah was Rehoboam's favorite among his eighteen wives. She was the granddaughter of Absalom, likely David's son. Maacah worshiped idols and negatively influenced Judah's spirituality (1 Kings 15:13).

1 Kings 15:3–5

Even though Abijam was unfaithful, God stayed true to his promise to David (2 Samuel 7:12–16; Psalm 89:19–29) and kept David's descendants on Judah's throne. Each king after David was meant to be a light, sharing God's grace (1 Kings 11:36).

1 Kings 15:6

Abijam inherited the conflict between the northern and southern kingdoms. Like Rehoboam (1 Kings 14:30), he went to war with Jeroboam. In one significant battle (2 Chronicles 13:2–20), Abijam's outnumbered forces were surrounded by northern troops. They called out to the Lord, and God helped them defeat Jeroboam decisively.

1 Kings 15:7

the rest of the acts: The writer of Chronicles notes that Abijam married fourteen wives and had thirty-eight children (2 Chronicles 13:21).

1 Kings 15:9

Asa ruled from 910 to 869 BC.

1 Kings 15:10

forty-one years: For the first ten years of Asa's reign, there was peace (2 Chronicles 14:1–7). This peace might be because his father decisively defeated Jeroboam.

1 Kings 15:11–13

- did what was right: Besides the reforms mentioned here, the writer of Chronicles notes the positive spiritual influence of God's prophet Azariah on the king (2 Chronicles 15:1–7). Asa also gathered a large assembly to renew the covenant with the Lord (2 Chronicles 15:9–15).
- shrine prostitutes: See 1 Kings 14:23–24. Asa worked to limit idolatry and pagan fertility rituals, even removing Maacah from her powerful position as queen mother (1 Kings 15:13; 2 Chronicles 15:16).
- The Kidron Valley was where reforming kings of Judah destroyed pagan idols (2 Kings 23:4–15; 2 Chronicles 29:16; 30:14).

1 Kings 15:14–15

Even though he let the pagan shrines stay, Asa stayed faithful to the Lord. People seemed to use these shrines to worship the Lord. In his later years, Asa's spiritual enthusiasm seemed to weaken (2 Chronicles 16:7–12).

1 Kings 15:16

Baasha started his rule in Asa's third year (1 Kings 15:33). Once Baasha was in power, Judah faced new conflicts with Israel. Asa also defended against an attack by Zerah the Ethiopian (2 Chronicles 14:9–12), likely a commander for Pharaoh Osorkon I, who ruled from 924 to 889 BC. Asa and his troops achieved a major victory and seized a large amount of loot from Zerah's forces and towns in the Negev, which likely initiated the Egyptian invasion.

1 Kings 15:17

Baasha moved south and recaptured towns that Abijam had lost (2 Chronicles 13:19), including Ramah in Judah, about four miles north of Jerusalem. This action closed the border, stopping Israelites from joining Judah and keeping Asa within his territory. Ramah controlled key north-south and east-west routes in Canaan (Judges 4:5; Isaiah 10:29; Jeremiah 31:15; 40:1).

1 Kings 15:18–19

Ben-hadad, the king of Aram, and his successors played a key role in Aramean-Israelite relations for many years. Asa asked Ben-hadad for help and offered valuable gifts from the temple treasury. Although the Arameans and Israel had been enemies before (1 Kings 11:23–25; 2 Samuel 8:3–12; 2 Chronicles 8:3–4), Ben-hadad and Baasha had formed a treaty. Asa knew he could buy the Aramean king's help for the right price (1 Kings 15:20). When God's prophet Hanani delivered

the Lord's rebuke to Asa for seeking Ben-hadad's help, Asa reacted unusually and imprisoned him (2 Chronicles 16:7–10). Asa seemed to forget God's earlier help against Zerah's large army (2 Chronicles 14:7–8).

1 Kings 15:20–22

Because King Asa asked for help, the war with Baasha soon favored Asa. Ben-hadad quickly took over parts of northern Israel and secured key trade routes. This forced Baasha to stop his activities in Ramah to address the crisis in the north. Asa reclaimed Ramah and used its materials to strengthen other important border towns against Baasha's future actions.

1 Kings 15:23

he became diseased in his feet: We do not know the exact nature of Asa's sickness. The Jewish Talmud suggests it may have been gout (a painful disease of the joints). During his severe illness, Asa trusted only in his doctors and did not seek the Lord's help (2 Chronicles 16:12).

1 Kings 15:25–31

The writer of 1 Kings tells Nadab's life story using a common format (see study note on 1 Kings 15:1–8).

1 Kings 15:27–29

Baasha killed Nadab and all of Jeroboam's descendants, ending Israel's first family line of kings. Baasha's father was Ahijah, not to be confused with the prophet who predicted Jeroboam's family line of kings would end (1 Kings 11:29–39). Baasha's takeover was the first of several in Israel's history (for example, 1 Kings 16:9–10).

1 Kings 15:30–31

Jeroboam brought on the Lord's condemnation and judgment. His son Nadab continued in the same sins. Then Baasha became king and began a new dynasty (family line of rulers). This dynasty pushed Israel even further into spiritual weakness (1 Kings 15:34).

1 Kings 15:32–34

Baasha made Tirzah his capital, which was a royal retreat for earlier kings (1 Kings 14:17).

1 Kings 16:1

Jehu, like his father Hanani whom Asa had imprisoned (2 Chronicles 16:10), was a prophet. Jehu, also like his father, bravely delivered God's message everywhere, even if it meant facing the king.

1 Kings 16:2–4

The Lord accused Baasha of murder (1 Kings 16:7) and of following Jeroboam's idol worship. Since he continued Jeroboam's evil ways, Baasha and his family would face the same fate (see 1 Kings 14:11).

1 Kings 16:5–7

Jehu the prophet worked in both Israel and Judah. He wrote about events during Jehoshaphat's reign, which were included in The Book of the History of the Kings of Israel (see 2 Chronicles 20:34).

1 Kings 16:9–10

Elah got drunk in Tirzah while his army fought for their lives in the Philistine-controlled city of Gibbethon (1 Kings 16:15). This showed his poor character. He was even less suitable to rule than his father, Baasha (see 1 Kings 16:13).

1 Kings 16:11–12

Zimri quickly and ruthlessly executed all of Baasha's family, relatives, and friends. Although Zimri carried out the Lord's judgment on Baasha's dynasty, he likely acted out of self-interest. He wanted to prevent them from seeking revenge or using their power to stage their own takeover.

1 Kings 16:15–17

Even though Zimri led half of the royal chariots (1 Kings 16:9), he stayed in Tirzah instead of joining the army attacking Gibbethon. The armed forces did not respect him; they viewed his actions as treason and chose their commander, Omri, as the new king of Israel.

1 Kings 16:18–19

burned it down upon himself: Zimri's cowardice shows when he chooses to kill himself rather than face capture.

1 Kings 16:21–22

Tibni is only mentioned in this passage, and Ginath is not known. In the Greek Old Testament, Tibni's brother Joram helped him in his unsuccessful attempt to gain power. Both Tibni and Joram died in the conflict with Omri.

1 Kings 16:23

Omri ... reigned twelve years: His son Ahab became king in the seventh year of Omri's reign (see 1 Kings 16:29). This suggests that Omri's twelve-year rule likely

included about four years when he and Ahab ruled together.

1 Kings 16:24

Omri founded the city of Samaria and moved the capital there from Tirzah. Samaria remained Israel's capital until it fell in 722 BC. This location offered Israel a central and defensible hill in the northern kingdom, allowing control over the trade routes below. Omri enjoyed his new capital for only six years before he died (1 Kings 16:28).

1 Kings 16:25–26

evil: When Israel moved from the first family line of rulers to the second (1 Kings 15:33–34), the change of rulers did not improve the nation's spiritual condition.

1 Kings 16:27–28

the might he exercised: Although the Old Testament mentions Omri briefly, people in nearby lands knew him well. The Moabite Stone (Mesha Stela) says Omri conquered land north of the Arnon River in Moab. Assyrian kings showed his importance by calling Israel the "House of Omri." If Omri arranged his son Ahab's marriage to Jezebel (daughter of Ethbaal, king of Tyre and Sidon, 1 Kings 16:31), as was common in the ancient Near East, he likely gained more political and trade recognition.

1 Kings 16:31–33

Ahab is considered the worst king of Israel in terms of spirituality. People later blamed his bad actions on his wife Jezebel's influence (1 Kings 21:25). Ahab and Jezebel promoted Canaanite religious practices, which led Israel away from God. Combined with Jeroboam's false worship, these actions eventually brought disaster to Israel.

1 Kings 16:34

- Despite Joshua's curse on Jericho (Joshua 6:26–27), people sometimes lived there before Hiel rebuilt it (see Judges 3:13; 2 Samuel 10:5; 1 Chronicles 19:5), as shown by archaeological digs. Hiel's actions show Israel's spiritual decline.
- he laid its foundation ... Segub: The Targum (an Aramaic translation with explanations for Jews who no longer knew Hebrew after the exile in Babylon) says that Hiel sacrificed his sons as foundation offerings, following pagan practices. Others believe his sons died from disease or accident. The Hebrew wording may also be a merism (a figure of speech using two extremes to mean the whole), which would suggest that all of Hiel's sons died.

1 Kings 17:1

- Elijah was God's prophet to the northern kingdom during the reigns of the third-dynasty kings:
- Ahab, who ruled from 874 to 853 BC,
- Ahaziah, who ruled from 853 to 852 BC, and
- Joram, who ruled from 852 to 841 BC.
- Elijah showed his dedication to the Lord by declaring that he served the living God of Israel.
- Elijah stopped the dew and rain to challenge Baal, who supposedly controlled these natural forces. Their absence, until God instructed Elijah to speak, started the contest with Baal that would peak on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18).

1 Kings 17:1–19.21

The prophet Elijah's work was closely tied to his spiritual growth. Elijah challenged Israel's interest in Baal, the Canaanite storm god. During this conflict, Elijah saw God's power and support, unlike Baal's weakness. This was shown in Elijah's contest with Baal's prophets on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18:1–46). After fleeing from Jezebel, God renewed Elijah's mission at Mount Sinai (1 Kings 19:1–18). Elijah's mission was finished by his successor, Elisha (1 Kings 19:19–21).

1 Kings 17:2–7

- Kerith Brook was a safe place for Elijah during the drought God caused (see 1 Kings 18:10). The food and water there showed Elijah that God was protecting him.
- When the water source dried up, Elijah had to move to a new place.

1 Kings 17:9–11

- Zarephath was in Phoenician territory. It was about seven miles south of Sidon, outside Ahab's control. In an ironic twist, God gave Elijah a place of safety in Jezebel's homeland, a region known for the worship of Baal.
- Elijah got up and went: Elijah once more obeyed the Lord's command (see 1 Kings 17:5). He had key traits for successful spiritual service:
- obedience (1 Samuel 15:22; Psalm 40:1–6; Isaiah 1:10–20),
- trust (Psalm 37:3; Proverbs 3:5–6), and

- faithfulness (Psalm 18:25; Revelation 2:10).
- God's ongoing care for Elijah and the widow of Zarephath showed His concern for everyone who prioritizes Him.
- water ... bread: Elijah asked for basic needs, but these were scarce as the drought affected Phoenician territory.

1 Kings 17:9–16

Elijah's faith faced another test. At Kerith Brook, God directly provided for him. When those supplies stopped, Elijah had to rely on a foreign woman's reaction to a divine test. The story has four parts:

1. The setting (1 Kings 17:8–10a).
2. Elijah's test for the widow (1 Kings 17:10b–14).
3. The woman's obedience (1 Kings 17:15).
4. God's reward (1 Kings 17:15–16).

1 Kings 17:12

As surely as the LORD your God lives: This wording shows Elijah's promise and statement to Ahab (1 Kings 17:1). The non-Jewish woman's promise does not mean the Lord is her god, but it assures Elijah she is telling the truth.

1 Kings 17:13–14

Even though the woman had few supplies (1 Kings 17:12), Elijah asked her to serve him before herself and her son. Like the poor widow who gave two small coins (Luke 21:1–4), this woman was asked to give everything she had to God's prophet. True faithfulness means putting the kingdom of God before personal needs (Matthew 6:33).

1 Kings 17:15–16

She followed Elijah's instructions, and God rewarded her faith. The daily supply of essentials reminded her of God's faithfulness and goodness (Lamentations 3:22–24; Philippians 4:19).

1 Kings 17:17

until no breath remained in him: All attempts to dismiss the following miracle contradict the clear statement.

1 Kings 17:17–24

This story starts with the woman's doubts about Elijah (1 Kings 17:17–18) and ends with her recognizing the power of God's word through Elijah (1 Kings 17:24). Interestingly, this non-Israelite widow acknowledged God's miraculous power, while God's own people, Israel, had forgotten his mighty acts.

1 Kings 17:18

my iniquity: The widow believed the common idea that suffering or disaster always comes from a person's own sins. But the Bible shows this is not always true (see Job 4:7; Luke 13:1–4; John 9:1–3).

1 Kings 17:19

In ancient Near Eastern culture, Elijah likely stayed in a separate room with an outside stairway. This setup protected the woman's reputation and gave Elijah some privacy.

1 Kings 17:20

have You also brought tragedy: Elijah sadly asked God if his presence caused the child's death.

1 Kings 17:21

We do not know what life-giving power Elijah intended to show by touching the dead boy, but he clearly trusted in the Lord. Elisha later did a similar ritual when the Lord brought back to life the dead son of the woman from Shunem (2 Kings 4:32–37).

1 Kings 17:22–24

The miracle of the child's resurrection rewarded Elijah's faith and confirmed the mother's trust in God's prophet. Her story suggests she put her faith in the Lord. Jesus mentioned her as an example of God's care for non-Israelites and to show that God's messengers are often more accepted by outsiders than by their own people (Luke 4:24–26). The Scriptures often highlight God's care for widows to show his concern for those in need (Exodus 22:21; Deuteronomy 10:18; 27:19; Psalm 68:5; Isaiah 1:17; James 1:27).

1 Kings 18:2

Elijah kept following the Lord's commands (see 1 Kings 17:5, 10), even though it was risky to meet Ahab.

1 Kings 18:3–6

Because of the severe drought, Ahab and Obadiah, his chief officer (see 1 Kings 4:6; 16:9), went to find enough water and grass for the king's horses. These supplies were essential for military readiness. Assyrian King Shalmaneser III wrote that Ahab used about 2,000 horse-drawn chariots in the Battle of Qarqar in 853 BC. Solomon also had many horses and chariots (1 Kings 10:26).

1 Kings 18:4

Obadiah's care for 100 of the Lord's prophets suggests a group of prophets that existed since Samuel's time (1 Samuel 10:5–18; 19:20, 24). These groups met for study and spiritual support and are mentioned several times (2 Kings 4:1, 38; 9:1). Elijah and Elisha likely led some of these groups (2 Kings 2:3–7, 15; 6:1–7).

1 Kings 18:10

no nation or kingdom: In the ancient Near East, it was common to return fugitives or runaway slaves. This is noted in the treaty between Pharaoh Ramses II and the Hittite king Hattusilis. However, Elijah did not need to ask a foreign king for protection. God kept him safe at Kerith Brook (1 Kings 17:3) and with the widow at Zarephath (1 Kings 17:9).

1 Kings 18:12–15

Obadiah, a true believer, knew that God's Spirit worked through the prophets (Judges 6:34; Ezekiel 3:12, 14; 11:1). He feared the Spirit might take Elijah away while he told Ahab where Elijah was. The king might then think Obadiah was hiding Elijah and kill him.

1 Kings 18:16–18

troubler: Although Elijah announced the drought (1 Kings 17:1), Ahab and his family caused God's judgment on Israel. They broke the covenant and promoted Baal worship (see Leviticus 26:19; Deuteronomy 28:15, 23; 2 Chronicles 7:13; Jeremiah 14:1–7; Amos 4:7–8).

1 Kings 18:19–20

Mount Carmel is on a ridge that separates the coastal plain of Palestine. The site was famous for Canaanite idol worship, and an altar to the Lord was also built there earlier (1 Kings 18:30). It was a natural place for the contest with Baal. The Septuagint (a Greek translation of the Old Testament) might suggest that the prophets of Asherah were present at the contest on Mount Carmel, but the Hebrew text does not confirm this (compare 1 Kings 18:22).

1 Kings 18:21

The Hebrew word translated waver means "to be lame" or "to limp." Elijah compared the people's indecision between worshiping the Lord and Baal to someone limping awkwardly from one foot to the other. Elijah might have also referred to the ritual dance performed by Baal's prophets as they tried to get the storm-god's attention (1 Kings 18:26).

1 Kings 18:22

the only remaining prophet of the LORD: Obadiah had earlier hidden two groups of fifty prophets to keep them safe from Jezebel's purge (1 Kings 18:4, 13). However, Elijah's public role likely made him feel isolated in his fight against false religion (see 1 Kings 19:10, 14). He indeed stood alone when facing the 450 prophets of Baal.

1 Kings 18:23–24

Fire showed the Lord's presence (Exodus 9:23; 19:18; 40:38; Deuteronomy 4:24; 2 Chronicles 7:1; Isaiah 66:15; Amos 7:4), which could have been lightning (see Psalm 18:12–13; Ezekiel 1:13–14; Zechariah 9:14). The contest aimed to prove if Baal, the Canaanite storm god, or the God of Israel was the true God. Only the true God could ignite the wood (see Leviticus 9:24).

1 Kings 18:27

occupied: Elijah mocked the false gods by speaking as if they had human needs. His sarcasm showed how powerless they were. In some religions, such as in Egypt, priests treated idols like people. They would wake up the idol, feed it, wash it, dress it in fresh clothes, put makeup on its face, and place a royal emblem on it.

1 Kings 18:28–29

shouted ... cut themselves ... raving: This behavior was typical in ancient pagan religions, but their actions received no response. There is only one true God (Deuteronomy 4:35; 6:4; Isaiah 44:8), and all other hopes will fail (Isaiah 45:22).

1 Kings 18:31–32

The twelve stones Elijah used to rebuild the altar for the Lord should have reminded the people that God was the redeemer of all Israel (compare Joshua 4:1–11; see Isaiah 41:14; 49:26).

1 Kings 18:33–35

Elijah made sure there could be no doubt or trickery. He poured a large amount of water on the offering and the wood. The water may have come from the nearby Mediterranean Sea or the Kishon River.

1 Kings 18:36

At the time set for the sacrifice to the Lord, Elijah prayed. He did not copy the wild behavior of Baal's prophets. Instead, he prayed to God, remembering his promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Genesis 50:24; Exodus 3:6, 15; 4:5; Numbers 32:11; Deuteronomy 9:27).

1 Kings 18:37

The pattern of calling and answering appears often in the Old Testament. It shows the close relationship between a person who prays and the Lord who listens and responds (Job 14:15; Psalms 4:1; 91:15; 102:2; Isaiah 65:24; Jeremiah 33:3).

1 Kings 18:38–39

The Lord sent fire that burned everything, even the water in the trench. This showed clearly that the Lord is truly God. The story that follows makes it certain that the Lord, not Baal, rules over fire, water, and the weather.

1 Kings 18:41–45

The servant saw a small cloud on the horizon, about the size of a hand. It signaled the coming of a huge rainstorm.

1 Kings 18:46

- He tucked his cloak into his belt to run faster ahead of Ahab's chariot. The Hebrew phrase means doing something with energy or enthusiasm (2 Kings 4:29).
- Jezreel was located between Megiddo and Beth-shan in the southeastern part of the Jezreel Valley, about seventeen miles from Mount Carmel.

1 Kings 19:2

Jezebel threatened to kill Elijah within a day by speaking a curse. Solomon had made a similar threat against his half-brother Adonijah (1 Kings 2:23), and the king of Aram later used the same approach against Elisha (2 Kings 6:31). Jezebel was determined and ruthless in achieving her goals (1 Kings 21:5–15).

1 Kings 19:3

- Elijah was scared: The New Living Translation, the Berean Standard Bible, and many scholars translate Elijah's reaction as fear, using the Hebrew word wayyira' ("he feared"). The Hebrew text we have says, "he saw it" (wayyare'), meaning he saw the danger in Jezebel's threat. Instead of a warm welcome after his great victory and hoping for the royal family to repent, Elijah faced a death threat.
- Beersheba was at the southern end of the country. A common phrase described the land's boundaries as "from Dan to Beersheba" (1 Kings 4:25; 2 Samuel 24:2).

1 Kings 19:4

- Although technically a shrub, the broom tree can grow up to ten feet tall. Its small leaves still offer enough shade for a tired traveler in the wilderness. Like Jonah (Jonah 4:3), Elijah completed his mission but felt disappointed with the outcome.
- no better: God's prophet, seeking refuge, felt he achieved little and thought he would be better off dead.

1 Kings 19:5–7

The angel of the Lord gave Elijah exactly what he needed at that time (1 Kings 17:2–6, 10–12). God often sent an angel to help one of his servants (Psalm 34:7; Hebrews 1:14).

1 Kings 19:8

Elijah was determined to reach Mount Sinai, a journey of about 200 miles. This trip did not need to take forty days and nights. Elijah might have traveled at a symbolic pace, reflecting Israel's history. Moses spent forty days on Mount Sinai, and Israel wandered in the wilderness for forty years (Numbers 14:33–34; Deuteronomy 1:2–3). The number forty sometimes symbolized a complete period of testing (Genesis 7:4; Psalm 95:10; Jonah 3:4; Matthew 4:1–2).

1 Kings 19:9–10

- a cave (literally the cave): Some suggest Elijah came to the same place where God appeared to Moses (Exodus 33:21–23).
- What are you doing here, Elijah?: The Lord's question might mean two things:

1. Why had Elijah come?
2. And did he grasp the importance of the place where he stood?

Elijah answered the first part of the question. He had bravely declared he was alone in his commitment to the Lord (1 Kings 18:22). Now, that feeling had turned into self-pity.

1 Kings 19:11–12

Powerful natural events sometimes show God's presence (Exodus 3:2; 19:18; Psalms 68:7–8; 114:4; Hebrews 3:6–7). However, this time, Elijah felt God's presence through a gentle whisper.

1 Kings 19:13–14

What are you doing here, Elijah?: The Lord asks the question again (see 1 Kings 19:9), and Elijah responds the same way as before. Elijah's answer shows he did not understand how God was working through the events. Paul refers to this exchange in Romans 11:3–4.

1 Kings 19:15–17

- Go back ... and go: With loving patience, God renewed his prophet's mission (see John 21:15–19). God told Elijah to return to where he had left God's mission; from there, he could move forward.
- Hazael and Jehu became instruments of God's judgment (2 Kings 8:7–15; 9:14–37).
- Elisha, who succeeded Elijah, would bring spiritual insight and further judgment to Israel (2 Kings 3:10–19; 8:7–15; 9:1–10:31; 13:3, 15–19).
- Abel-meholah was south of Beth-shan, where the Jezreel Valley and the Jordan Valley meet (see 1 Kings 4:12; Judges 7:22).

1 Kings 19:18

- The Lord corrected Elijah's thinking. The prophet was not alone. Earlier, he forgot about the 100 prophets protected by Obadiah (1 Kings 18:4, 13). Now he learned that 7,000 others stayed faithful to the Lord.
- bowed ... kissed him: These were common ways to show submission in the ancient Near East (2 Kings 21:3; Isaiah 46:6; 60:14; Hosea 13:2). They are often mentioned in the records of victorious kings or ancient stories. Ashurbanipal reported that during his sixth campaign, an Elamite king kissed his royal feet and cleaned the ground with his beard. In the Mesopotamian creation story (Enuma Elish, V 86), even the great gods bowed down and kissed the feet of Marduk, the victorious leader of the gods.

1 Kings 19:19

- Twelve teams of oxen suggest that Elisha's family was rich.
- Elisha knew that Elijah's power from God would pass to him with the prophet's cloak.

1 Kings 19:19–21

The anointing of Elisha concludes the Lord's instructions to Elijah. Elisha performed the other two anointings that God had originally assigned to Elijah (1 Kings 19:15–16), as recorded in (2 Kings 8:7–15; 9:1–10).

1 Kings 19:21

- Elisha burned his plow and slaughtered his oxen to show he was leaving his old life behind. From then on, he would serve the Lord. His meal with family and friends might have been a thanksgiving sacrifice to God, ending with a joyful meal celebrating God's call on Elisha's life.
- Elisha would first serve as the assistant of Elijah. Great leaders often start as good learners. Joshua was the assistant of Moses (Exodus 24:13) before becoming his successor (Numbers 27:18–23; Deuteronomy 34:9) and leading the forces of Israel (Joshua 1:1–9). Later, Elisha had an assistant named Gehazi (2 Kings 4:12).

1 Kings 20:1

- We do not know if this refers to Ben-hadad I or II.
- Accompanied by thirty-two kings: Groups of kings often united in the ancient Near East. Shalmaneser III recorded Ben-hadad's name as Hadadezer and noted he was in a twelve-king alliance against him at the Battle of Qarqar in 853 BC.

1 Kings 20:2–4

Ben-hadad's first group of messengers demanded that Israel surrender its treasures and people. Ahab agreed, wanting peace no matter the cost. He was willing to give up royal treasures and even his family to avoid a bloody war with a powerful enemy.

1 Kings 20:7–9

- When Ben-hadad's second group made even bigger demands (see 1 Samuel 11:1–2), Ahab realized Ben-hadad wanted war. Ahab agreed to the first demand but refused the second.
- my lord the king: Ahab spoke to Ben-hadad politely, showing he was willing to accept the Aramean king's rule. He might have hoped his polite response would prevent a fight.

1 Kings 20:10–11

- Ben-hadad's third group gave an ultimatum: Surrender or die. His harsh threat to plunder Samaria was reinforced with a curse. This was a form of psychological warfare common in the ancient Near East (see 2 Kings 18:19–35).
- Ahab's third response to Ben-hadad included wise sayings. The conflict's outcome was still uncertain.

1 Kings 20:12

Ben-hadad and the other kings were drinking in their tents, expecting Ahab to surrender. Ahab's response was a challenge, so the Aramean officers got ready to attack.

1 Kings 20:13–16

Ahab's forces attacked around noon after a prophet promised them victory. The Jewish historian Josephus thought this prophet might have been Micaiah (see 1 Kings 22:8). The Israelites attacked during the hottest part of the day (see Joshua 8:14), catching the enemy off guard. Ben-hadad and the allied kings were still

drinking, showing their lack of respect for Ahab's military strength.

1 Kings 20:13–34

Two separate battles took place, one in Samaria (1 Kings 20:13–25) and another at Aphek (1 Kings 20:26–34). The writer shared similar details for both:

1. advice before the battle (1 Kings 20:13–14, 23–25),
2. conditions before the battle (1 Kings 20:15–16, 26–28),
3. Israel's victory despite being outnumbered (1 Kings 20:17–21, 29–30), and
4. advice after the battle (1 Kings 20:22, 31).

1 Kings 20:17

marched out first: Ahab seems to have sent this small squad to test the enemy. In the ancient Near East, surprise attacks often divided soldiers into groups with special purposes:

1. To attack from two sides at once (a pincer movement) (Judges 7:16; 1 Samuel 11:11).
2. To trick the enemy into chasing them into an ambush (Joshua 8:15–22)
3. To draw the enemy to a place where the attacking army had the advantage (Judges 4:14–16; 5:19–21).

1 Kings 20:20–22

- Horses and chariots were important in ancient battles. Ahab's defeat of most of Ben-hadad's forces was crucial to prevent future attacks. However, God's prophet warned that the king of Aram would come back.
- in the spring: Late spring and early summer were common times for war in the ancient Near East. Armies could rely on good weather and grain from the early harvest.

1 Kings 20:23

The Arameans thought that Israel's God had power only in the hills. This mistake gave the Lord an opportunity to show his true identity (1 Kings 20:28). Ben-hadad's officers had a pagan way of thinking. They may have believed this error because of Israel's history on Mount Sinai, where the Lord appeared to his people (Exodus 19:1–3, 16–18) or because Israel lived for a long time in the hill country of Canaan (see Joshua 10:40; 11:16; Judges 1:19).

But the Arameans did not know the truth: the Lord is the Creator and ruler of all the earth (Isaiah 40:28; 54:5). He is the only God, and only he can save (Isaiah 45:5, 22).

1 Kings 20:24–25

Ben-hadad's commanders believed they could easily defeat Israel on the plains with their skilled leaders and superior troops and equipment.

1 Kings 20:26

Aphek was east of the Sea of Galilee in northern Ramoth-gilead. Ben-hadad's officers thought this place would benefit the Aramean chariots and weaken Israel's "gods of the hills."

1 Kings 20:27–30

- Even though the Arameans had more soldiers, Israel won a great victory with God's help. Everyone learned that "nothing is impossible with God" (Luke 1:37; see Matthew 19:26; Mark 10:27). When God supports you, the enemy will retreat (Psalm 56:9) and suffer heavy losses (Deuteronomy 32:30–31; 2 Kings 19:32–36). Israel could face their enemies without fear (Psalms 3:6; 27:1–3).
- God's promise to Israel through the prophet showed that this battle was for both Israel's safety and the Lord's glory.

1 Kings 20:31

sackcloth ... ropes: Ben-hadad's officers knew the kings of Israel were often merciful. They advised approaching Ahab with signs of humble repentance (Joel 1:13; Jonah 3:5–9) and submission (Job 12:18; Lamentations 1:14). Ancient Near Eastern art often shows captured enemies with ropes around their necks. Assyrian kings bragged about piercing the lips or cheeks of their captives with ropes.

1 Kings 20:32–33

my brother: Ahab spoke to Ben-hadad in a polite way, showing respect for the Aramean king's authority and Ahab's wish for good relations. Ahab invited Ben-hadad into his chariot to warmly welcome him and to show that he should see Ahab as his equal. In the ancient Near East, kings spoke to each other as brothers to express friendship, good relations, or formal equality.

1 Kings 20:34

- The treaty between Ahab and Ben-hadad treated both sides equally, but it favored Ahab as the winner.
- The towns Israel lost to Aram (1 Kings 15:20) were returned, and Ben-hadad agreed to important trade deals with Ahab. Ahab likely thought this would be

profitable and give him an ally against the growing power of Shalmaneser III of Assyria.

1 Kings 20:35–43

Ahab showed mercy to Ben-hadad, which displeased God. An unnamed prophet used symbolic actions to show this disapproval. God's prophets often used symbols to deliver his messages (Isaiah 20; Jeremiah 27:1–7; Ezekiel 4:1–3, 9–17; 5:1–4). By sparing an untrustworthy enemy, Ahab brought judgment on himself and his people instead of relying more on the Lord.

1 Kings 20:36

a lion will kill you: In the past, a lion was a tool for divine judgment (1 Kings 13:20–24). It would serve this role again when Israel was repopulated after Samaria's fall (2 Kings 17:25–26).

1 Kings 20:42

devoted to destruction: See "Complete Dedication" Theme Note.

1 Kings 20:42–43

The Lord had told Ahab to execute Ben-hadad (see Joshua 6:17–21), but Ahab disobeyed. He might have seen the Aramean king as a prize of war (see 1 Samuel 15:1–23). Ahab, the king of Israel, would later regret this mistake. He faced Ben-hadad in another battle, which led to his own death (1 Kings 22:29–37). Instead of learning from the prophet's warning, Ahab returned home angry and upset.

1 Kings 21:1

- Besides his palace in the capital city, Ahab had another palace in Jezreel. Excavations in Jezreel have uncovered a large palace.
- Samaria, which sometimes refers to the capital city, refers here to the entire northern kingdom.

1 Kings 21:1–16

The writer shares another event where King Ahab reacted with anger and sulking (1 Kings 20:43; 21:4).

1 Kings 21:2–3

Naboth turned down Ahab's generous offer to buy or trade land for his vineyard. Naboth wanted to sell, but the law required inherited property to remain with the original family or tribe (Leviticus 25:23–28; Numbers 36:7–9). Unlike kings of nearby nations who could take any property they wanted (1 Samuel 8:11–17), Ahab had to follow Israel's law.

1 Kings 21:4

sullen and angry: Ahab reacted the same way when God's prophet scolded him (1 Kings 20:43). A stubborn, self-centered person can easily become sullen (1 Kings 21:16, 20, 25–26; see 16:31–32; 18:10, 17; 20:42–43; 22:3, 27–30).

1 Kings 21:7

I will get you the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite: Jezebel's ruthless actions showed her cultural background. Canaanite kings acted as they wished (1 Kings 21:8–10, 15, 25; see 19:1–2; 2 Kings 9:30–31).

1 Kings 21:8–9

among the people: This type of meeting usually dealt with sin that might lead to divine punishment (see Deuteronomy 21:1–9; Joshua 7:10–12; 1 Samuel 7:1–6). Jezebel called it to falsely accuse an innocent person.

1 Kings 21:10

- scoundrels (literally sons of Belial): This Hebrew term describes completely wicked people (Deuteronomy 13:13; Judges 19:22; 1 Samuel 10:27; Proverbs 6:12). Later Jewish texts associated Belial with Satan, a connection Paul also makes in the New Testament (2 Corinthians 6:15).
- Legally, two witnesses were required to confirm a charge against someone (Deuteronomy 19:15; Matthew 18:16). Naboth faced a double accusation of blasphemy against God and the king, which led to a death sentence by stoning outside the city (Deuteronomy 17:5–6; 22:24). Naboth was likely executed on his own land (see 2 Kings 9:21–26).

1 Kings 21:13–14

Like Achan (Joshua 7:24–26), Naboth's sons were killed at the same time (2 Kings 9:26). This was to stop the property from going to them. The charge led to a state execution (Deuteronomy 13:10–11; 17:5). With no male heirs left, Ahab used his royal right to take the property (1 Samuel 8:14).

1 Kings 21:17–22

Elijah announced God's judgment on Ahab as he was about to take over the vineyard. Since Ahab caused Naboth's death and took his field, Ahab and his family would be destroyed. The prophecy about Ahab's children would come true when Jehu removed Baal worshipers from Israel (2 Kings 9:30–37; 10:1–11).

1 Kings 21:25–26

The author pauses his story to highlight Ahab's evil nature, criticize the king's dedication to idol worship, and blame him for being influenced by his wife Jezebel. Jezebel, who was wicked, would do anything to get what she wanted (1 Kings 18:4; 19:1–2; 21:5–10, 15). Although she remained arrogant and defiant until the end (2 Kings 9:30–31), she eventually faced her foretold fate (1 Kings 21:23; 2 Kings 9:32–37).

1 Kings 21:27–29

Ahab was a complicated person. He was rightly criticized for his evil actions, but he did repent when a prophet delivered a message of rebuke (1 Kings 21:27). Because Ahab repented, the Lord sent Elijah to delay the terrible punishment meant for Ahab and instead place it on his equally wicked sons (2 Kings 1:17; 9:24–26; 10:1–11).

1 Kings 22:1

Three years passed without war: During this time, the Assyrian king Shalmaneser III, who ruled from 858 to 824 BC, repeatedly pushed westward, leading to the Battle of Qarqar in 853 BC. Shalmaneser's records say he fought against both Hadadezer (also known as Ben-hadad) and Ahab at this battle. When the Assyrian king was temporarily stopped, old hostilities between Aram and Israel reignited.

1 Kings 22:2–4

Jehoshaphat and Ahab were related because Ahab's daughter, Athaliah, married Jehoshaphat's son, Jehoram (2 Kings 8:25–26). Jehoshaphat intended his visit to be friendly, but he quickly got involved in Ahab's plan to capture Ramoth-gilead. The threat from Assyria had stopped Ahab from controlling this important area, which was at the eastern end of the Plain of Jezreel. Now, they needed to take it by force, and Jehoshaphat offered his troops and horses to help Ahab.

1 Kings 22:5–9

Following ancient Near Eastern tradition, Jehoshaphat asked the two kings to seek God's will before battle. This tradition appears in Aramean, Moabite, and Assyrian writings, as well as in the Old Testament (1 Samuel 23:2–4; 2 Samuel 5:19–25). Despite Ahab's doubts, Jehoshaphat insisted on calling Micaiah, a true prophet of God.

1 Kings 22:10

In the ancient Near East, people often conducted important business at the threshing floor near the city gate. David acquired Araunah's threshing floor and built an altar there (2 Samuel 24:18–25; 1 Chronicles 21:26). This site later became the location for the Temple in Jerusalem (2 Chronicles 3:1).

1 Kings 22:13–14

The messenger told Micaiah to agree with the false prophets. But Micaiah promised to deliver only the Lord's true message (see Numbers 22:38; 24:13).

1 Kings 22:15–16

Micaiah was speaking in a sarcastic way. Some translations, like the New Living Translation, make clear what Ahab sensed in Micaiah's tone of voice (1 Kings 18:27; Job 12:1–2; 16:2). The BSB leaves the description of tone unstated.

1 Kings 22:17

Like God himself (Psalm 23; Isaiah 40:10–11), Israel's kings and leaders were responsible for caring for the people, much like a shepherd cares for sheep (Numbers 27:16–17; Ezekiel 34:2, 11–16). The idea of the shepherd and the sheep, related to the coming Messiah (Ezekiel 34:23–24), was fulfilled in Christ, the Good Shepherd (John 10:1–11). Although he sacrificed his life for the sheep (John 10:14–18; 1 Peter 2:24–25), he still lives (Hebrews 13:20) and will return for them (1 Peter 5:4).

1 Kings 22:19–23

Micaiah said God let a lying spirit mislead Ahab to cause his death. God used Ahab's false prophets to fulfill His plan.

1 Kings 22:24–25

Zedekiah, a false prophet, angrily claimed he and the others were truthful. Like Ahab, they would eventually learn the truth when Jehu's purge of Baal worship came true (2 Kings 10:18–28).

1 Kings 22:29–33

Ahab wanted to avoid direct revenge from Ben-hadad by wearing a disguise. He encouraged Jehoshaphat to wear his royal robes so Ahab could avoid being noticed and try to prevent Micaiah's prophecy from coming true.

1 Kings 22:34–36

An Aramean soldier's random shot fulfilled Micaiah's prophecy about Ahab's death. Ancient armor found in the Near East shows that the arrow likely hit a small unprotected spot between the breastplate and the lower armor's metal pieces. Although badly wounded, Ahab showed courage by staying upright in his chariot during the day's battle before ordering a retreat.

1 Kings 22:37–38

Elijah predicted that dogs would lick Ahab's blood after he died (1 Kings 21:19), and this came true.

1 Kings 22:39–40

Archaeologists have found Ahab's palace and a nearby pool at Samaria. The palace is described as ivory, likely due to its ivory-covered furniture and wall panels. The building's exterior, made of shiny white limestone, also gave it an ivory-like appearance.

1 Kings 22:41–50

This summary gives basic information about Jehoshaphat's 25-year rule as king of Judah. The Chronicler shares more details about Jehoshaphat's strong spiritual character, which led to religious changes and blessings from the Lord (2 Chronicles 17:1–21:1). Including a two-year shared rule with his father, Asa, Jehoshaphat ruled from 872 to 848 BC.

1 Kings 22:43–44

Jehoshaphat is remembered as a king who pleased the Lord. But his record was not perfect. He did not remove all the pagan shrines (see 1 Kings 15:14). He also joined with Ahab (1 Kings 22:4, 29–32; 2 Chronicles 19:1–3) and later with Joram (2 Kings 3:4–27).

1 Kings 22:46

Jehoshaphat deserves credit for getting rid of religious prostitutes. His father, Asa, had banned them (1 Kings 15:12), but they still existed. These prostitutes were likely based at pagan shrines that Asa did not remove (1 Kings 15:14).

1 Kings 22:47

Edom not having a king might show that Edom relied on Judah during this period.

1 Kings 22:48–49

- Jehoshaphat built a fleet of trading ships with Ahaziah (see 2 Chronicles 20:35–37). Like Solomon, they planned to send ships to Ophir for gold (1 Kings 9:27–28; 10:11). But the plan failed. To fulfill a prophetic warning (2 Chronicles 20:37), the Lord destroyed the fleet before it left port. Jehoshaphat wisely refused to join with Ahaziah again.
- Ezion-geber was Solomon's port city on the Gulf of Aqaba (1 Kings 9:26).

1 Kings 22:51–53

The sad story of Ahaziah's rule in Israel continues in 2 Kings 1:1–18. He followed the evil ways of his parents, Ahab and Jezebel (1 Kings 21:25–26). He worshiped Baal (2 Kings 1:2, 16) and supported the state religion started by Jeroboam I (1 Kings 12:28–32). Ahaziah's rise to power and character summary conclude Ahab's story in 1 Kings and smoothly transition to the ongoing story of the divided kingdom in 2 Kings.